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Bachelor Thesis

Beyond Technology

Cross-Country Differences and the Adoption of Swedish Digital Operational Tools in Britain



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Abstract

This thesis explores the influence of organisational and cultural differences between Sweden and Britain, on the adoption of Swedish digital operational tools by companies in Britain. Digital transformation is critical for small and medium sized organisations (SMEs), but rolling out software across borders can create considerable operational and behavioural friction. Data were collected through in-depth interviews with managers, executives, and operators in both countries using a qualitative, multiple-case study design. The empirical findings were continually analysed by merging the Technology Acceptance Model (TAM), the Technology, Organization, Environment (TOE) framework and the CAGE distance framework. The analysis reveals the extent to which perceived usefulness and perceived ease of use are mediated by national corporate environments, with Swedish firms employing flat structures and informal peer-to-peer superusers to reduce implementation friction, while the more hierarchically and structurally accountable British market is afflicted by deep generational skills gaps and acute monitoring anxiety. The vertical structure in Britain means that shop-floor workers view real-time tracking as a surveillance tool, rather than a tool to enable collaborative execution. This requires highly structured, continuous training programmes to overcome organisational inertia. In conclusion, this study concludes that successful cross-border technology transfer cannot be based on technical function alone, and digital solution providers need to actively adjust their deployment strategies to fit the specific institutional trust scales, administrative distance, and leadership dynamics of the target market.

Key words

Technology Acceptance Model (TAM), Cross Border Friction, Digital Tools, Sweden, Britain.

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Appendices

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1. Introduction

This chapter presents the introduction and background of the chosen thesis research topic. Followed by the problem discussion that will identify the research gap and highlight managerial gaps regarding friction and cross-border adoption challenges due to organizational and cultural differences between Sweden and the United Kingdom. One main research question and three sub-questions are presented, followed by the purpose of the study. Lastly, the introduction is concluded with some delimitations and a thesis outline to provide a clear structure of the thesis.

1.1 Background

In today's contemporary business landscape. The transition to Software as a Service (SaaS) has fundamentally changed how today's businesses operate. As Oliveira et al. (2019, p. 2) point out, “SaaS solutions are no longer regarded as mere IT tools, but as key drivers of organizational agility”. By facilitating real-time data integration whilst reducing the need for significant upfront investment in infrastructure. SaaS enables businesses to respond more dynamically to market fluctuations. This change is particularly relevant for operational management, where digital dashboards have replaced traditional physical methods. Allowing for greater transparency and more informed decision-making processes.

Sweden is the clearest example of this digital maturity. According to the European Commission’s Sweden 2024 report (2025b), the country has consistently led the continent because “Swedish enterprises show high levels of digital intensity, particularly in cloud computing and data analytics adoption, significantly outperforming the EU average.” (p.4). This is no coincidence, but rather the result of a deliberate focus on innovation. Andersén (2022, p.45), explains this phenomenon in greater detail through the “attention-based perspective”, stating that, in Swedish manufacturing companies, they have entrepreneurial orientation and a focus on environmental sustainability. As the European Commission’s Sweden 2024 report (2025b) points out, Sweden’s digital strategy is now focused

on “the dual transition, where digitalization is harnessed to achieve ambitious environmental goals”. (p. 9).

Whilst technology is adopted uniformly and rapidly in the Nordic countries, the picture in Britain is far more uneven. In Britain, the economic landscape is fragmented, which consequently poses significant challenges for the internationalization of SaaS providers. A study by Daams et al. (2024, p.2) highlights a persistent structural problem known as "the productivity paradox." Furthermore, it notes that "regional differences in productivity within the United Kingdom have increased significantly over the last decade. Whilst capital investment remains largely concentrated in the London metropolitan area.” This geographical concentration of wealth and technology means that industrial firms in the north or the Midlands often operate under different financial constraints. For Swedish providers of digital operational tools, preparing to enter the market of a potential British client is often hampered by what Daams et al. (2024, p.19) describe as “a chronic lack of investment in digital infrastructure outside the major economic centres.” This structural deficit directly erodes the organizational readiness, as firms operating with outdated regional infrastructure lack the baseline technical compatibility required to deploy advanced SaaS solutions. Consequently, these uneven productivity levels diminish the willingness of local management to adopt new tools, as leaders under financial strain tend to prioritize immediate operational survival over long-term digital modernization.

The internationalization process for Swedish SaaS companies is further complicated by the increase in “administrative distance”, resulting from the British departure from the European Union. This change in the law (due to Brexit) is no longer merely a matter of political debate. It has become a real problem for software sales. These legal issues not only make everything more expensive, but they also worry British business leaders. As can be seen, the United Kingdom is no longer just a close neighbor for Swedish companies. It is now a market with its own rules, forcing companies to adapt their strategy to overcome “the end of the easy, frictionless trade that once existed” (Moloney and Jensen, 2024, p. 12).

Beyond that, it is clear that the entry of Swedish SaaS companies into Britain is limited by a highly complex environment. Although cloud technology offers an opportunity for strategic agility, according to Oliveira et al. (2019, p. 2), its implementation is hampered by local economic realities and the investment gaps

identified by Daams et al. (2024, p. 44). These systemic gaps mean that uneven regional development acts as a direct operational barrier that shapes manager psychology, significantly reducing their willingness to experiment with unfamiliar foreign platforms. Consequently, the current landscape for the internationalization of Swedish providers of digital operational tools depends not only on the technical superiority of the software, but also on the ability to navigate a British market that is currently torn between the need for modernization and the barriers imposed by its own economic and political situation. This set of pressures defines the context in which Swedish companies must operate today. Consequently, the market suitability of these solutions depends not only on technical functionality but heavily on how these digital operational tools interface with the distinct management practices and leadership dynamics embedded within the British corporate environment. Understanding these complex intersections requires a systematic exploration of how firm-level and country-level factors directly restrict or enable this technological journey, establishing the exact focus of the empirical inquiry presented in the following sections.

1.2 Problem Discussion

Many organizations are currently introducing digital systems to improve communication, coordination, and operational follow-ups within their daily management work. Traditional tools that gave safety and structure in the past do not give the same value as they did before. These tools can be everything from whiteboards to spreadsheets. Manual reporting is still widely used in operational environments, even though these methods may create challenges related to communication, information sharing, and long-term follow-up processes (Fast-Berglund et al., 2016; Robinson, 2023). As a result of this, companies today are focusing on cloud based solutions to increase the value. This has become increasingly relevant for organizations attempting to improve efficiency and visibility in their work.

At the same time, the implementation of a digital system is not always simple and straightforward. Even when the system offers a good technical solution, organizations may still decline it. The acceptance of the employees, operational routines, and organizational change all play a vital role in the decision. Furthermore, organizational culture, leadership, and employee attitudes may

influence whether digital systems are successfully adopted in practice (Oyetade et al., 2024). This becomes increasingly important due to the practicality of operational environments where digital tools play a vital role in affecting daily routines, communication, and performance follow-ups.

The research problem behind this study originates from Boards on Fire, a Swedish SaaS company that provides digital operational management tools primarily within the Swedish market. While the company has established customers in Sweden, it currently does not operate within the British market. This created an interest in understanding whether organizational culture, digital readiness, and country-specific factors may influence how British organizations respond to Swedish digital operational tools. Since the implementation of digital daily management systems depends heavily on employee acceptance, organizational routines, and operational practices, uncertainty remains regarding how these systems would be perceived and adopted within British organizations compared to Swedish environments.

The problem becomes even more important in international business settings since today, companies are expanding into foreign markets where organizational, environmental, and working culture differences exist. Johanson and Vahlne (2009) talk about the firms that enter international markets, they often face uncertainty connected to unfamiliar business environments and organizational practices. Digital firms are also victims of this, many are capable of rapid internationalization yet may still encounter challenges related to market conditions, customer behavior, and organizational differences across countries (Strandberg, 2017).

Although there is extensive research regarding digital transformation, SaaS adoption, and internationalization separately, fewer studies focus specifically on how organizational culture and cross-country differences influence the adoption of digital operational tools in practice. This creates a research gap regarding how digital daily management systems are perceived and adopted in organizations operating in different national and organizational environments.

1.3 Research Gap

The research done by Johanson and Vahlne (2009), on internationalization has traditionally focused on how firms expand into foreign markets through market

selection, international growth, and foreign market commitment. At the same time, research about the adoption of technology has mainly been talking about organizations and how they internally respond to technological systems. The focus has always mainly been about the readiness of an organization, employee acceptance, leadership, and technological capabilities (Oyetade et al., 2024; Hoang, 2024). Although both research areas discuss organizational adaptation and change, they are often studied separately, despite the fact that the influence of digital operational tools are both done in organizational conditions and international business environments.

Research that exists on digital transformation usually focuses on technology implementation where the organizational settings are broad or more focused on the customer-facing digital systems (Hoang, 2024). Due to this, less information can be found about digital operational tools used for internal daily management, communication, operational follow-ups, and performance monitoring inside organizations. Systems such as digital dashboards directly influence operational routines, reporting structures, communication processes, managerial practices, and decision-making activities within organizations (Dowding et al., 2015).

Unlike traditional IT systems, the digital operational tools are closely integrated into the everyday operational work of organizations. Omelianenko and Ilienkov (2024) have talked about the operational digital transformation and that it shows how these systems may change workflows, communication structures, organizational routines, and operational management practices within firms. Digital operational systems are therefore not only technical tools, but also organizational systems that influence how employees communicate, collaborate, monitor performance, and respond to operational issues in real time. As a result, the success of the adoption may depend heavily on how well these systems can be aligned with the already existing organizational routines, workplace culture, and managerial practices.

Research also suggests that organizational environments supporting collaboration, learning, communication, and technological adaptation are often more open to digital transformation processes (Wang and Rafiq, 2014; Ogbonna and Harris, 2000). However, previous studies have largely examined these organizational factors within domestic settings, while less attention has been given to how organizational culture may influence the adoption of digital operational tools across different national environments.

Sweden is considered one of the more digitally advanced countries in Europe. Therefore, this idea is increasingly relevant to Sweden and the United Kingdom. The association between Sweden and high levels of digital maturity and technological integration across organizations has been very noticeable lately, and many public institutions thrive because of this (Borg et al., 2018; Øvretveit, 2019). At the same time, managerial approaches of organizations that operate in different national environments may face some differences. Operational routines and readiness for digital transformation are also huge differences in these matters. The research done by Hitz and Schwer (2018) presents the idea that digital transformation and digital operating models often require organizational adaptation, communication, and alignment between operational processes and digital systems.

Studies about digital transformation, SaaS adoption, and organizational culture have already been done by many so far, but separately. Limited attention has been given to how digital operational tools are adopted within business-to-business organizational environments, especially from the different national contexts. The research that has been done so far was more broadly focused on technology adoption or customer-facing systems, while less attention has been directed toward operational tools used for internal communication, daily management, performance follow-ups, and operational coordination.

The end result of this, is that there remains a research gap regarding how organizational culture and national working environments may influence the adoption of digital operational tools, especially within B2B operational settings. This study therefore aims to contribute to the existing literature by examining how organizational culture, digital readiness, and country-specific conditions may influence the adoption of Swedish digital operational tools within British organizations.

1.4 Purpose

The purpose of this study is to explore and analyse how cultural and organizational differences between Sweden and Britain may influence the adoption of Swedish digital operational tools in the British market.

More specifically, the study aims to identify the cultural and organizational factors that may shape the adoption of these tools, and to examine how differences

between the Swedish and British business contexts may create barriers or facilitators in the adoption process.

By focusing on these issues, the study seeks to provide a deeper understanding of how digital operational tools developed in one national business context may be received, interpreted and adopted in another.

1.5 Research Question

How do cultural and organizational differences influence the adoption of Swedish digital operational tools in the British market?

1.5.1 Sub-questions

1. Which organizational and cultural factors influence the adoption of digital operational tools?
This sub-question provides the theoretical foundation for the study and will mainly be answered through the literature review. It focuses on identifying the organizational and cultural factors that previous research highlights as important for the adoption of digital operational tools.

2. How do differences between the Swedish and British business contexts influence the adoption of digital operational tools?
This sub-question will be addressed through both the literature review and the interviews. The literature review helps explain relevant differences between the two business contexts, while the interviews provide insight into how these differences may affect adoption in practice.

3. Which barriers and facilitators may arise from these cultural and organizational differences in the adoption process?
This sub-question will be answered through the interviews. It focuses on the challenges and supporting factors that may emerge when Swedish digital operational tools are introduced in the British market, and how cultural and organizational differences may make adoption easier or more difficult.

These sub-questions help break down the main research question by focusing on the theoretical factors, the differences between the Swedish and British contexts, and the barriers and facilitators that may arise during the adoption process.

1.6 Delimitations

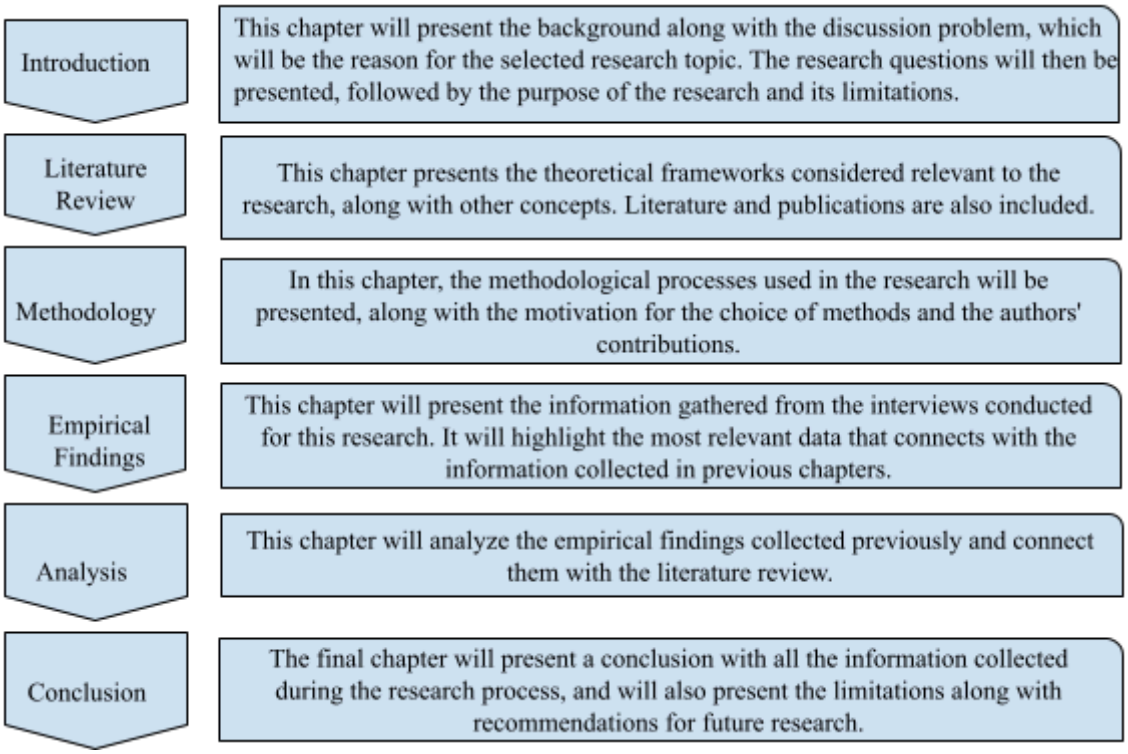
This study focuses on the adoption of Swedish digital operational tools in the British market. It does not aim to explain the adoption of digital operational tools across all industries, firms or countries. Instead, the study focuses on how organizational and cultural differences may influence adoption in this specific Swedish and British business context.

The geographical focus is limited to Sweden and Britain. Sweden is relevant because the study includes perspectives from a Swedish provider and Swedish user firms, while Britain is examined as the target market. Although some of the literature refers to broader Nordic patterns of digital maturity, the empirical focus remains on the Swedish and British contexts.

The study is also limited to organizational and cultural aspects of adoption. This means that the focus is on factors such as organizational readiness, leadership, work practices, trust and cultural differences. The study does not evaluate the technical quality of the software itself, and it does not examine a full international expansion strategy.

The empirical material is based on a limited number of qualitative interviews with respondents from Sweden and Britain. The findings should therefore be understood in relation to this specific research context, rather than as results that can be statistically generalized.

1.7 Outline


Introduction
This chapter will present the background along with the discussion problem, which will be the reason for the selected research topic. The research questions will then be presented, followed by the purpose of the research and its limitations.
Literature Review
This chapter presents the theoretical frameworks considered relevant to the research, along with other concepts. Literature and publications are also included.
Methodology
In this chapter, the methodological processes used in the research will be presented, along with the motivation for the choice of methods and the authors' contributions.
Empirical Findings
This chapter will present the information gathered from the interviews conducted for this research. It will highlight the most relevant data that connects with the information collected in previous chapters.
Analysis
This chapter will analyze the empirical findings collected previously and connect them with the literature review.
Conclusion
The final chapter will present a conclusion with all the information collected during the research process, and will also present the limitations along with recommendations for future research.

2. Literature Review

This chapter presents the theoretical perspectives relevant to the study. Since the research focuses on how organizational and cultural differences may influence the adoption of digital operational tools, the literature review is structured around four areas. First, it addresses organizational and cultural factors influencing technology adoption. Second, it discusses barriers and facilitators to adoption. Third, it examines cross-country differences between Sweden and Britain. Finally, these perspectives are brought together in an analytical framework.

2.1 Organizational and Cultural Factors Influencing Technology Adoption

Technology adoption in firms is shaped by more than the technical features of a system. It is also influenced by internal conditions within the organization and by the wider cultural context in which adoption takes place. It is therefore relevant to examine both organizational and cultural factors when studying the adoption of digital operational tools.

2.1.1 Organizational Factors:

Organizational factors are variables that are internal, and they determine whether the system or tool will be implemented and if it even fits the organization in practice. It has to align with the way employees operate on a daily basis and how it can benefit them in both the short and long run (Oyetade et al., 2024).

According to Oyetade et al. (2024), the culture of the organization, leadership, and the availability of resources are all critical factors in determining whether the new tool or system is successfully embraced within the organization.

A common way to understand this is through the Technology Acceptance Model (TAM). In simple terms, people are more likely to use a system if they feel it helps them do their job and isn’t too complicated to handle (Marikyan and Papagiannidis, 2025). If a tool makes work easier, people tend to accept it. If it

feels confusing or unnecessary, they usually avoid it (Marikyan and Papagiannidis, 2025; Wang et al., 2025).

At the same time, these perceptions don't just appear on their own. The organization plays a big role in shaping them. Leadership is a clear example. When managers actively support a system and explain why it matters employees are more likely to take it seriously and give it a chance (Oyetade et al., 2024).

Resources also matter more than many companies expect. The system might be well designed, but if employees don't have time to learn it or don't get proper support, they will likely avoid using it. Organizations that invest in training and support usually face fewer problems during adoption (Aljaraidah, 2026).

Another important aspect that should be looked at is how well the system fits into everyday work. If employees can clearly see that a new tool makes their tasks easier, then they will be more willing to use it. Yet, if the new system or tool feels unnecessary or disconnected from what they actually do, resistance is more likely to happen. This shows that adoption is not just about the technology itself but rather more about how well it is introduced and supported within the organization itself (Oyetade et al., 2024; Aljaraidah, 2026).

However, organizational factors alone may not fully explain why employees respond differently to technological change. Wider cultural and societal influences may also shape attitudes toward digital adoption.

2.1.2 Cultural Factors:

Not everything can be explained by organizational factors alone. The way that new technologies are viewed is also influenced by culture. This will determine how the employees react to the change, how comfortable they are with new experiences, and how ready they are to modify their habits and adapt to what the company has decided (Oyetade et al., 2024).

Common working and thinking behaviours can provide insight into a company's culture where employees at a particular firm are accustomed to experimenting with new ideas and streamlining processes. Others like to adhere to predetermined schedules. These distinctions influence how open employees are to new systems, yet, businesses that promote learning and flexibility are more likely to change,

whereas harsher settings meet more opposition and pushback (Oyetade et al., 2024).

Another issue is uncertainty, new systems usually alter the way work is done, which can make people nervous, especially if they are unsure about the outcome. This is especially important for organizations with a global presence. Employees from various countries and backgrounds may respond differently to the same change because cultural remoteness can increase uncertainty and influence how decisions are made in a range of contexts (Gollnhofer and Turkina, 2015).

Ghemawat (2001) created the CAGE framework to assist people in understanding these anomalies. It identifies four types of distance that firms must consider while conducting international business. Cultural distance is related to differences in language and values. Administrative distance may be characterized as differences in laws and rules. The geographical distance is the distance between infrastructure and physical locations, economic remoteness reflects changes in market conditions and income levels (Ghemawat 2001).

In general, cultural differences show that external influences, rather than internal decision-making, drive technological adoption. It is influenced by the people's activities and environment in which the organization operates (Oyetade et al., 2024).

2.1.3 Connecting Organizational and Country Culture

The national environment and the organizational culture are deeply connected, and that will influence how companies operate. The social culture will influence the behaviours of the people working, it will influence their communication styles, managerial approaches, and expectations within organizations (Yaprak et al., 2015). As a result, employees from different countries may respond differently to organizational change and digital implementation processes, even when the same technological system is introduced (Yaprak et al., 2015).

In this study, organizational culture is viewed as a reflection of the broader national cultural aspect. Societal values and working norms are points that influence the behaviors, communication styles, and managerial practices within organizations.

According to Ghemawat (2001), this distance becomes especially relevant for companies operating internationally because digital systems are introduced across

multiple organizational and national contexts. The differences between countries may create a cultural and administrative distance that may influence international business activities and organizational practices. From the cultural distance perspective, Ghemawat (2001) highlights the differences in values, communication styles, and social norms, while administrative distance relates to differences in institutional structures, regulations, and business environments.

Furthermore, these differences may influence how digital operational tools are perceived and integrated into everyday work practices (Oyetade et al., 2024). The organizational environments that encourage flexibility, collaboration, and learning are often seen as more open and friendly to the idea of innovation and technological change. Yet, the way employees interpret new systems and organizational changes may still vary, this depends on the broader national working cultures. Previous experiences with technology adoption is also a point that must be taken into consideration (Oyetade et al., 2024).

These differences may become important during the international implementation processes because the organizations that operate in different or multiple national environments may not respond to digital systems in the same way. Both the organizational and country-specific conditions are important points to pay attention to since they could be a massive help in explaining variations in technology adoption across markets (Ghemawat, 2001; Oyetade et al., 2024).

2.2 Barriers and Facilitators to Adoption

In addition to broader organizational and cultural factors, technology adoption is also influenced by more specific barriers and facilitators. These help explain why some firms adopt digital tools relatively smoothly, while others hesitate or struggle to make them part of daily work. In this study, barriers refer to factors that may slow down or complicate adoption, whereas facilitators refer to factors that support adoption and make implementation more likely to succeed. This is important because firms do not adopt digital tools simply because the technology is available. Adoption also depends on how the tool is perceived by users and whether the organization has the conditions needed to support its use (Oliveira et al., 2019; Oyetade et al., 2024).

For SaaS solutions, adoption is often understood through the interaction between technology, organization and environment. Oliveira et al. (2019) argue that SaaS adoption is shaped not only by the characteristics of the technology itself, but also by internal organizational conditions and the wider environment in which the firm

operates. This is particularly relevant for digital operational tools, since such tools are closely linked to routines, information sharing and decision-making. A firm may therefore need more than access to a technically strong solution. It also needs internal readiness, managerial support and routines that allow the tool to become part of everyday work.

Technology acceptance research also highlights the role of user perceptions. The Technology Acceptance Model suggests that users are more likely to accept a system when they perceive it as useful and easy to use (Marikyan and Papagiannidis, 2025). These ideas are relevant in this context, since employees and managers need to understand both the value of the tool and how it fits into their work. At the same time, SaaS adoption should not be reduced to individual perceptions alone. It also needs to be understood in relation to the organization around the tool, such as readiness, leadership, resources and the wider environment in which the firm operates (Oliveira et al., 2019; Oyetade et al., 2024).

2.2.1 Barriers

One important barrier is perceived complexity. If employees experience a digital tool as difficult to understand, time-consuming or poorly connected to existing routines, adoption may become more difficult. This relates to perceived ease of use, since users are less likely to accept a system if it feels unnecessarily demanding (Marikyan and Papagiannidis, 2025). In the case of digital operational tools, this can happen when the system changes how information is reported, how work is followed up or how employees are expected to use data in everyday operations. This also connects to organizational differences, since a tool may be perceived as more complex when it does not fit well with existing routines, structures or ways of managing daily work.

Another barrier is low perceived usefulness. If employees or managers do not understand what a tool is supposed to improve, it may be viewed as another system to manage rather than as something that supports their work. This is especially relevant for digital operational tools, where the value often lies in better visibility, improved coordination and stronger support for decision-making. If these benefits are unclear, adoption may become difficult even when the technical solution itself is strong (Marikyan and Papagiannidis, 2025). Differences in organizational

priorities and working practices may therefore influence whether the tool is seen as genuinely useful in the first place.

Resistance to change is also relevant. Oyetade et al. (2024) identify organizational culture, employee attitudes, leadership, resource availability and user perceptions as important internal factors in ICT adoption. This suggests that resistance is not always directed at the technology itself. It may also reflect uncertainty about why the tool is being introduced, how it will affect established routines or whether employees feel included in the process. When the purpose of adoption is unclear, employees may continue to rely on familiar ways of working rather than fully engaging with the new system. This is relevant here because employees may react differently to new tools depending on how their workplace usually handles change, communication and involvement.

Limited competence and support can create further problems. A tool may be formally introduced without being properly used if employees do not feel confident enough to work with it. Oyetade et al. (2024) emphasize the role of skills, user perceptions and resource availability, while Oliveira et al. (2019) show that SaaS adoption is shaped by several conditions around the technology, the organization and the wider environment. This means that adoption may be held back if users lack training, time or practical support. This is closely linked to organizational conditions, since firms differ in how much competence, training and internal support they are able or willing to provide during adoption.

Resource limitations can also slow down adoption. While SaaS solutions may reduce the need for large investments in local IT infrastructure, implementation still requires time, internal coordination and managerial attention (Oliveira et al., 2019). A firm may therefore hesitate to adopt a digital operational tool if it lacks the capacity to introduce it properly or if other operational priorities are seen as more urgent. Such limitations are organizational in nature, as they reflect the firm's internal ability to prioritize and support the adoption process.

Uncertainty and perceived risk should also be considered. Oliveira et al. (2019) explain that SaaS adoption can involve concerns related to data security, provider dependence, system reliability and integration with existing systems. In a B2B setting, these concerns may become even more important because digital operational tools can involve internal performance information and business-critical processes. If decision-makers are unsure about such issues, adoption may be delayed even if the tool seems useful. In a cross-country setting, these concerns may become even more relevant if firms evaluate trust, external providers and operational risk differently across national business contexts.

Weak strategic alignment can become a barrier. Oyetade et al. (2024) argue that ICT adoption is influenced by how well technology initiatives align with organizational strategies. If a digital tool is introduced without a clear connection to the firm's goals, users may struggle to understand why it matters. For digital operational tools, this is especially important because they are closely linked to planning, communication and improvement work. Without strategic alignment, adoption may remain fragmented instead of becoming embedded in the organization. This makes strategic alignment an important organizational issue, since adoption is more difficult when the tool does not connect clearly to the firm's wider priorities and way of working.

2.2.2 Facilitators

A key facilitator is clear perceived usefulness. When employees and managers can see how a system improves their work, adoption becomes more likely (Marikyan and Papagiannidis, 2025). In relation to digital operational tools, this may involve a better overview, reduced manual work, clearer information and improved coordination. The more clearly the tool addresses problems that users already recognize, the easier it becomes to view it as relevant.

Ease of use can also support adoption. If a tool feels manageable, users are more likely to engage with it. For digital dashboards and operational tools, this may involve clear visualizations, understandable functions and a design that fits daily routines. A system that feels easy to work with may lower the effort associated with adoption and make regular use more likely (Marikyan and Papagiannidis, 2025).

Leadership support is another important facilitator. Oyetade et al. (2024) show that leadership, organizational culture and resource availability influence ICT adoption. Managers can support adoption by explaining the purpose of the tool, providing resources and making the technology part of the firm's priorities. This support needs to be practical as well as symbolic. Employees need to understand not only that the tool should be used, but also why it matters and how it fits into their work.

Training and internal support are closely connected to this. If users receive guidance and time to learn the system, they are more likely to build confidence and use the tool consistently. This matters for digital operational tools because they may affect how information is reported, shared and used in decision-making. Oyetade et al. (2024) emphasize the importance of internal support structures, skills and resource availability in ICT adoption.

Organizational readiness is also central. Oliveira et al. (2019) show that SaaS adoption is shaped by organizational conditions as well as technological and environmental factors. Readiness may include digital competence, existing infrastructure, managerial commitment and routines for handling change. A firm that already has these conditions in place may find it easier to integrate a new digital solution into everyday work.

The literature shows that barriers and facilitators are not only about the technology itself, but also about the organization in which the tool is introduced. Adoption is more likely when a tool is perceived as useful and manageable (Marikyan and Papagiannidis, 2025), and when the organization provides support through leadership, training and readiness for change (Oyetade et al., 2024). By contrast, adoption may become more difficult when a tool is perceived as complex or uncertain, or when it is poorly aligned with existing routines and organizational priorities (Oliveira et al., 2019; Oyetade et al., 2024). These perspectives are important for this study because they help explain why firms may respond differently to digital operational tools, and why adoption depends on more than the technical features of the solution. In this study, leadership support, training, internal support and organizational readiness are mainly seen as internal organizational facilitators, since they depend on the firm's own structures, resources and ability to support change. Perceived usefulness and ease of use are also important, but they become especially relevant in the British market context, where Swedish digital operational tools may be interpreted differently depending on local routines, expectations and ways of working.

Since this study focuses on Swedish digital operational tools in the British market, these barriers and facilitators also need to be understood in relation to the cross-country differences discussed in the following section.

2.3 Cross-country Differences between Sweden and Britain

Since this study is conducted in a transnational context, it is necessary to consider how structural and cultural differences between Sweden and the United Kingdom influence technology adoption. Following the CAGE Distance Framework (Ghemawat, 2001), the gaps that shape this process for cross-border B2B SaaS solutions are analyzed.

2.3.1 Organizational Contrasts: Digital Maturity and Management

At the organizational level, it is important to consider that the main difference lies in the Digital Readiness of companies and their internal management practices.

Digital Intensity in SMEs: The first observation is that Sweden presents a highly advanced panorama in terms of digital intensity. This is because 86.6% of SMEs exhibit at least a basic level of digital readiness (European Commission, 2025b). On the other hand, it has been observed that digital adoption rates in British SMEs are significantly lower than in leading countries such as Sweden (UK Department for Business & Trade, 2026). This shows an adaptation challenge for the provider's digital value proposition.

Management Practices: In this sector, it was noted that SMEs do not typically spend money or time training their managers or improving work organization. This is critical for this case study, as the British government states that improving management by just 0.1 points in the British management scores would be associated with a 9.6% increase in productivity (UK Department for Business & Trade, 2026). Considering this information, the digital operational tool could serve as a tool to raise the management scores. It would help companies make the leap in management quality that the British government is requesting.

Infrastructure Support: While Sweden is a benchmark with 85.6% fiber optic (FTTP) coverage (European Commission, 2025a), Britain faces challenges in accessing high-speed internet, lagging behind the EU average in this indicator (European Commission, 2025a). This physical distance can affect the Perceived Ease of Use (TAM) of a cloud solution when implemented in British firms.

2.3.2 Cultural Contrasts: Skills and Communication Styles

National culture acts as a filter on how technology is perceived and accepted by the workforce in each market.

Human Capital and Skills: Sweden has demonstrated that they have the highest proportion of ICT graduates in the European Union (European Commission, 2025a). Thus, in Sweden, there is a culture where the average employee is more familiar with advanced software. In contrast, Britain has demonstrated that it faces a skills gap. With 15% of companies report that their employees are not fully competent (UK Department for Business & Trade, 2026). This indicates that, in one out of every seven companies, there are employees who lack the required

skills to perform their current jobs in an effective way. If they already struggle to perform their basic tasks, launching new software, such as digital boards, can be seen as a burden or a complicated tool to understand. With this data, the digital daily management system may require additional facilitators. Such as intensive technical training, ongoing support, and simplified interfaces, to overcome this barrier in Britain.

Decision-Making Styles: Swedish organizational culture is characterized by flat hierarchies and consensus-based decision-making. While in Britain, decision-making tends to be more centralized and hierarchical. For the software solution, this implies that the adoption process in British firms could depend more on an executive mandate than on the collective consensus of employees.

Attitudes towards digitalisation differ significantly between Sweden and Britain. In Sweden, 85% of the population considers that digitalisation makes their daily life (European Commission, 2025a), which reflects a culture of trust in technology. Digitalisation is generally perceived as beneficial. In contrast, in Britain, only the 6.2% of companies offer training in basic digital skills, despite the high demand (UK Department for Business and Trade, 2026), contributing to an environment of uncertainty. This disparity directly affects the initial perceived usefulness, as defined by the Technology Acceptance Model (TAM), in which the British employees may attribute to a new digital management platform. With the introduction of the digital operational tool, the perceived usefulness may initially be low, not due to deficiencies in the software itself, but because employees may lack sufficient digital confidence to use it effectively.

2.4 Analytical Framework

The analytical framework of this study integrates established theoretical models with the purpose of analyzing how national and organizational variations shape cross-border technology adoption. Instead of using these theories separately, the combination of them helps us to organize each one to answer a specific part of our main research question. The functions of these theories are divided as follows:

The Technology Acceptance Model (TAM) (Marikyan and Papagiannidis, 2025) answers the individual level, that is, the part of the research question that centers on the users. It explains how the ultimate intention to adopt a digital tool is

dictated by individual cognitive perceptions, specifically, whether users perceive the system as useful and easy to use.
Ghemawat's (2001) CAGE Distance Framework answers the general level, environmental part of the research question. It shifts the focus from the individual towards the country context, systematically evaluating how cultural, administrative, geographic, and economic distances between Sweden and the United Kingdom create structural friction and alter technology transfer across borders.
The Technology Organization Environment (TOE) Framework (Oliveira et al., 2019) answers the meso-level, organizational execution part of the research question. Specifically, the Organizational context of TOE provides the theoretical support to analyze the internal dynamics of the firm. It explains how the company's own attributes, meaning internal readiness, leadership commitment, formal training mechanisms, and cultural resistance, act as the internal engine that either facilitates or obstructs the transition from national-level distance to individual acceptance.

By structuring the analysis around this integration, the framework comprehensively addresses the research question from the broad environmental (CAGE), the mid-level organizational (TOE), and the individual level (TAM) at the same time.

The systematic interaction between these frameworks operates as a multi-layered filter. Specifically, country-level distances within the CAGE framework (such as administrative post-Brexit barriers and hierarchical cultural distance) dictate the external environment and heavily constrain the organizational readiness and technological infrastructure within the TOE framework. In turn, these firm-level structural conditions and leadership styles directly determine the micro-level cognitive parameters of the Technology Acceptance Model (TAM). If a firm faces high cultural distance and low organizational readiness, it directly diminishes the end-user's perceived ease of use and perceived usefulness, creating operational friction. Conversely, when structured training under TOE mitigates the cultural gap, it positively stimulates TAM variables, accelerating the adoption process.

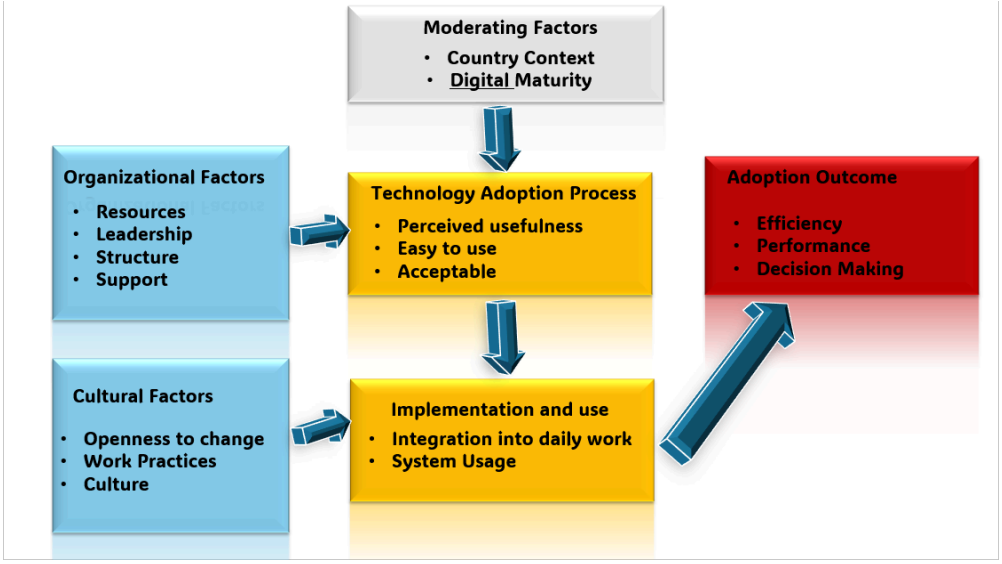
The first part of this analysis examines the overall economy, the leadership, the outside environment, and how useful the tool is seen to be. Bloom and Van Reenen (2010) say digital tools are adopted when they help fix management problems and boost productivity. Here, productivity data from the UK Department for Business, Trade and Industry (2026) are used to check if digital tools can really solve national efficiency issues. In the TOE framework, leadership is treated as a key organizational resource. Leaders' commitment is important because a manager's vision directly affects how ready a company is; how useful the tool is seen depends not just on its features but also on whether leaders can connect it to the company's main goals and support it as a real management help instead of just extra work.

The second part connects cultural and company factors with how easy the software seems to use, influenced by overall market conditions and technical setup. According to the TOE framework, a company must be ready, meaning it has the right technology and skilled people, before adopting cross-border B2B SaaS adoption (Oliveira et al., 2019). The skill gaps that have been detected in some British market areas (UK Department for Business & Trade, 2026) create obstacles which make the software systems seem harder to use than they actually are. People in different markets have different levels of data experience and technical knowledge. Thus, under TOE, organized training and onboarding are seen as formal ways companies use to boost readiness and close skill gaps. Resistance here is not just individual refusal but a company-wide issue, explained by TOE. It often happens because the software was made in Sweden assuming users work independently, but British companies expect something different. Without local support and training that match each market's needs, this internal company friction will likely slow progress.

The intended use is shaped by administrative distance and by differences in decision-making styles between the two markets (Ghemawat, 2001). Sweden usually works by agreement and has flatter company structures, while Britain relies more on hierarchical decisions when introducing new tools. This means that adoption often depends on whether senior managers support it or not. This view Andersén (2022) shares, where he points out, the real problem is not just if the leaders see the value of these digital tools, but more importantly, whether they

have enough focus to handle it along with other priorities. The changes that need to follow local market rules can easily push aside digital modernization goals (Moloney and Jensen, 2024).

Thus, cross-border technology adoption only works if the local leaders see the system as a quick way to improve strategy rather than extra work. Under the lens of TOE, if organizational readiness (driven by proactive leadership) and capability building (supported by structured training) can outweigh the implementation costs and the structural resistance generated by cultural distance within the British market, the adoption process will be considered more feasible. This analytical framework provides the structural basis to derive conclusions regarding the necessary deployment strategies, thereby effectively bridging the gap between international business theory and the practice of technology adoption in the British market.



Model 1: Analytical framework of technology adoption in organizations
Source: Authors' own elaboration based on TAM (Davis, 1989) and Oyetade et al. (2024)

3. Methodology

In this section, the methodological framework that will be used to investigate the "Market Readiness" of Britain for Swedish SaaS tools is detailed. Our methodology plan is strictly based on the "Research Onion" model, proposed by Saunders et al. (2023).

3.1 Research Approach

When beginning a research project, the first step is to define the approach that best suits the study's objective. This section explains which approach is most appropriate for addressing the research question. As mentioned by Saunders et al. (2023), there are three main approaches: deductive, inductive and abductive.

Beginning with the deductive approach, the research will be guided by a theory. Often, this is developed from the academic literature, and a research strategy is designed to test that theory. Saunders et al. (2023), reveal that this approach moves from a general position to a specific one. It is frequently associated with quantitative research, in which hypotheses are used to verify whether the collected data fit the existing theory.

In contrast, the inductive approach starts by collecting data to explore a situation and then generates a theory based on the patterns identified. Saunders et al. (2023) state that this approach moves from distinct observations towards broader generalizations. This makes it ideal to comprehend the 'why' and 'how' of a human or organizational problem.

The final approach, the abductive approach, combines the two previous approaches, in which data are used to explore a phenomenon, identify themes and explain patterns within a conceptual framework. According to Saunders et al. (2023), abduction facilitates the researcher to move back and forth between theory and data. This is particularly useful when there is a wealth of information in a general context, but much less in the specific context under the study. This approach recognizes that, although we have existing theories, the real-world data can still reveal surprises, forcing us to adjust our theoretical interpretation.

For the purposes of this research, the abductive approach has been selected. According to the reasoning of Saunders et al., (2023), this approach is best suited to analyzing how differences in organizational culture between Sweden and Britain influence the adoption of digital tools. Given that our study employs frameworks such as Ghemawat's CAGE Distance Framework and the Technology Acceptance Model (TAM), abduction allows these theories to be used as a basis for guiding the interviews. Whereas keeping the necessary flexibility to uncover new cultural characteristics. It also allows the interviewees' actual experiences to help improve or expand these theories if the reality of the British market reveals unexpected barriers.

In practice, we experienced the abductive method throughout our entire analysis. We started from theory, using the core dimensions of TAM and CAGE to build our interview guide. However, once we started reading through the transcripts, the data pushed us back to the theory. For instance, our interviewees didn't just talk about general 'country differences'. They brought up very specific things, such as the lack of engineering backgrounds in Britain or how British leadership styles change the way data is shared. Rather than trying to force these practical insights into rigid theoretical boxes, we decided to go back to our framework and use these findings to break down the vague concept of 'country context' into concrete factors like local business rules and market conditions. By continually reviewing our interview data against our literature, we made sure our findings stayed grounded in theory. This, while still capturing the authentic and practical reality of the British market.

3.2 Research Method

The selection of an appropriate research methodology is important for obtaining beneficial results in any academic study. As indicated by Saunders et al. (2023), there are two main research methods, the qualitative and quantitative, and each offers specific values for exploring the research question. The fitness of each method and technique relies totally on the research problem and naturally on its main purpose. First, the quantitative method is linked to numerical data that is used to explore relationships between variables and typically uses statistical and graphical analysis techniques. This with emphasis on controlled measurement, logical analysis, and hypothesis testing.

However, the qualitative approach involves the compilation of primary and secondary data, which is not numerical, such as spoken or written words, through methods such as observation or interviews, allowing for a deeper understanding of the meanings that individuals attribute to social and organisational phenomena.

Given the complexity of understanding how differences in organisational culture and digital maturity influence technology adoption. This research requires a methodological approach able to capture subjective perceptions and contextual variations.

Consequently, the qualitative approach is presented as the most appropriate option for this study. In accordance with Yin's definition adopted by Saunders et al. (2023), this is described as an inquiry that investigates a contemporary phenomenon within its real-life context, particularly when the boundaries between the phenomenon and the context are not clearly evident. In this study, the context is defined by the interaction between two distinct ecosystems: the Swedish one, characterised by the high level of digital activity demonstrated by SMEs, and, on the other hand, the British one, which presents structural challenges such as the productivity paradox and uneven investment in digital infrastructure.

3.3 Research Design

Research design is defined as the structured plan that enables research questions to be linked to data collection and analysis coherently (Saunders et al., 2023). For this study, it has been decided to adopt an exploratory design.

To understand why the selected design is the most appropriate for our project, it is necessary to contrast it with descriptive and explanatory alternatives. As Saunders et al. (2023) explain, a descriptive design reduces research by focusing strictly on producing an accurate persons, events, or situations. Thus, in our case, a descriptive approach would map only the existing cultural characteristics of British firms or present a static picture of current software usage. Since our goal is to dig deeper than simply describing the current state, a descriptive approach is insufficient for our study. Likewise, Saunders et al. (2023) state that explanatory research defines causal relationships between variables. Given that cross-border technology adoption is highly dependent on fluid human perceptions and subjective organizational behaviors, rather than quantifiable cause-and-effect laws. Forcing our qualitative study into a rigid explanatory framework would cause us to miss the subtle aspects of the phenomenon.

Instead, our study is specifically exploratory because we are investigating an intricate area at which the boundaries between organizational culture and software acceptance are not yet clearly defined. According to Saunders et al. (2023), an exploratory study is mainly useful when the researchers aim to ask more open questions, which helps them gain a deep understanding, as well as to clarify a problem's exact nature. By focusing on how cultural and organizational differences

influence the daily adoption of digital operational tools, in this case, our exploratory design allows us to discover real-world resistance and informal management practices. Thus, unexpected operational barriers that standard surveys cannot capture.
This design election gives us the necessary flexibility that Saunders et al. (2023) associate with exploratory paths. This allows us to follow new insights as they emerge from our interviews, and at the same time, allows a deeper and more authentic understanding of cross-border B2B SaaS adoption.

3.3.1 Case Study

A case study is defined as a research strategy focused on understanding the dynamics of specific environments (Saunders et al., 2023). This methodology is particularly effective when the researcher seeks to answer ‘how’ and ‘why’ questions. This allows the phenomenon to be analysed without being separated from its real-world context. In this thesis, the use of the case study is fundamental, as the adoption of digital tools does not occur in a technical vacuum, but is essentially linked to the cultural norms and power structures of each country.

Currently, in line with the directions set out by Saunders et al. (2023), it has been noted that this research study employs a multiple case study design. Unlike an individual case study, the multiple-case design allows us to observe whether findings in one setting are replicated or contrasted in another. This provides the research with a higher capacity for theoretical interpretation. Thus, the ‘unit of analysis’ is not only the supplier company but, in this case, the process of cultural interaction between Sweden and the United Kingdom.

The choice of this strategy allows for an in-depth exploration of what Saunders (2023) terms ‘rich empirical evidence’. For instance, it makes possible the analysis of how flat hierarchies, which are common in the Swedish workplace, affect the implementation of software in Britain, which is a country where the organisational structure can be more vertical. By relying on multiple perspectives, from the CEO leading the expansion to consultants with local expertise. The case study ensures that the research captures the complication of digital internationalisation. This allows us to identify common patterns and critical differences that a purely statistical analysis would overlook.

3.3.2 Purposive Sampling

Continuing with sampling, which is a fundamental process for data collection, it enables researchers to obtain relevant information from suitable participants when it is not possible to cover an entire population due to time and resource constraints (Saunders et al., 2023). Among non-probability sampling strategies, this thesis employs purposive sampling, a method in which researchers apply their professional judgement to select cases that effectively address the research questions and thus fulfil the study's objectives (Saunders et al., 2023).

For this research, the participant selection criteria were rigorous and based on two pillars that we consider fundamental. As a starting point, we sought individuals who formed part of the strategic core of a Swedish software provider, alongside major Swedish multinational manufacturing enterprises. These specific Swedish firms are appropriate for studying our topic because they operate in an environment where flat organizations, high digital familiarity, and consensus-driven operational tracking are already the standard. Looking at these firms allows us to see the original environment where the visual software was designed to work. Secondly, business management professionals in the United Kingdom were included, representing core sectors like corporate law, regional media infrastructure, heavy engineering, and industrial assembly. These British firms that were selected provide the ideal contrast for our study because they operate in highly competitive, strictly regulated, and traditionally top-down corporate environments. By choosing British companies where digital tools must interact with complex local rules and clear hierarchies, our sample makes it possible to see exactly where the cross-border implementation friction happens. By incorporating interviewees from diverse professional backgrounds, ranging from executive management and software development to customer success management and the international consultancy, the sample allows us to have a more effective understanding of the facilitators, and barriers to digital internationalisation. This deliberate selection of interviewees, who combine technical knowledge with leadership experience in foreign markets, intends to highlight the differences and similarities in how Swedish and British organisations experience and respond to the adoption of new digital tools.

Even if there are clear advantages of this approach for our exploratory study, we must acknowledge the fundamental limitations of purposive sampling. As Saunders et al. (2023) mention, purposive sampling methods suggest that the sample is not, from a statistical perspective, a representation of the entire population. This prevents us from making broad statistical general statements, and

the selection is also susceptible to researcher bias, as it is based on our own professional judgment. In our case, these limitations were reflected in the practical difficulties that we faced during the data collection phase. Whereas we were able to conduct interviews in Sweden in a smoother way, accessing the British market proved much more difficult. This difficulty highlights the real challenge of cross-border research, where access to complex corporate environments can be restricted by varying levels of, in this case, institutional openness. This was demonstrated by one of our British interviewees, who was notably cautious about the depth of internal information the interviewee shared with us.

To reduce these limitations and ensure the credibility of our findings, for our study, we focused on data quality rather than only quantity, intentionally diversifying organizational roles on both sides. By incorporating the technical logic of the developers, the onboarding perspectives of customer success management, and the large-scale strategic views of senior management and consultants, we manage to balance our final sample with diverse professional perspectives. While we cannot statistically generalize our findings and acknowledge the limitations of operating in a more closed corporate environment in Britain, this multifaceted qualitative approach allows us to achieve a deep, yet high-quality, contextual understanding of technology adoption, which remains the primary objective of our exploratory design.

3.3.3 Cases

In total, 8 interviews were performed, four with representatives from Swedish enterprises (Respondents A, B, C, and D) and four with representatives from the United Kingdom (Respondents E, F, G, and H). To capture a complete picture of the cross-border technology transfer, these cases were structured to connect the provider's strategic perspective with the operational reality of the final users. For Respondent A, which is the Swedish software provider, the interview with the Chief Executive Officer (CEO) is relevant because it captures the original design philosophy, product value proposition, and the assumptions about user autonomy built into the software before it is exported.

To contrast this provider view with the actual domestic implementation, Respondents B, C, and D represent the Swedish user firms operating in manufacturing and industrial environments. The interviews with production managers (who oversee day-to-day shop floor operations), product managers (who align software capabilities with corporate strategy), and operations development

managers in these companies are relevant because these roles are directly responsible for managing internal readiness and visual communication workflows, showing us how the software operates in its domestic, flat organizational context. Finally, Respondents E, F, G, and H represent the British user firms embedded in sectors such as corporate law, media infrastructure, engineering, and industrial assembly. The interviews with former executive leadership, legal professionals, and operations or project managers in Britain are highly relevant to the adoption processes because these specific roles act as the primary implementation drivers in the target market. They are the ones who must navigate local skill gaps, deal with strict regional compliance rules, and decide whether the digital tool is successfully integrated into their top-down hierarchies or rejected due to operational friction.

Respondent Label	Company Context & Industry Sector	Role & Scope of Responsibilities	Region / Market
Respondent A	Digital Visual Management Software Provider: A specialized Swedish B2B SaaS organization that develops digital dashboards and operational coordination platforms designed to replace physical whiteboards and streamline corporate communication.	Chief Executive Officer (CEO): Responsible for the overarching strategic direction, internationalization frameworks, and product value proposition deployment across domestic and foreign target markets.	Sweden
Respondent B	Global Manufacturing & Access Solutions Firm: A prominent international production facility operating within a highly structured manufacturing environment utilizing lean production methods.	Production Manager: Oversees daily assembly line operations, manufacturing KPIs, and the implementation of operational tools to monitor floor-level efficiency and visual management.	Sweden
Respondent C	International Industrial Equipment Manufacturer: A major multinational enterprise specializing in heavy machinery, mining, and infrastructure equipment development with complex supply chains.	Operations Development Manager: Tasked with evaluating operational workflows, integrating digital tools for internal communications, and managing change resistance during software onboarding.	Sweden
Respondent D	Global Manufacturing & Access Solutions Firm: An international production entity focused on security, access control, and hardware infrastructure manufacturing with cross-border operations.	Product Manager: In charge of specific product lifecycle strategies, aligning market feedback with operational capacities, and coordinating data transparency across multiple European sites.	Sweden

Respondent E	Multinational Media & Newspaper Group: A massive media network headquartered in London, encompassing widespread print and digital news operations across 87 cities and 24 countries.	Former Chief Executive Officer (CEO): Accountable for global operational scaling, strategic performance follow-ups, and managing structural communication differences across international offices.	Britain
Respondent F	International Corporate Law Firm: A high-stakes legal services partnership based in London, managing large-scale cross-border M&A deals, private equity, and real estate transactions for major entities.	Corporate Law Professional: Responsible for legal document execution, regulatory compliance reviews, corporate deal mediation, and the daily adoption of data-sensitive digital legal software.	Britain
Respondent G	Industrial Manufacturing Organization: A British-based engineering and industrial assembly firm dealing with localized operational standards, workforce coordination, and visual performance tracking.	Operations & Strategic Manager: Oversees strategic resource planning, localized project implementation, and coordinates communication lines between administrative levels and shop-floor teams.	Britain
Respondent H	Engineering & Infrastructure Enterprise: A prominent British company focusing on infrastructure project execution, complex logistical planning, and multi-layered contractor management.	Operations & Project Manager: Directs on-site project execution, technical software integrations, data privacy compliance, and manages technical user training gaps during operational updates.	Britain

3.4 Data Collection

The empirical material in this study has mainly been collected through semi-structured interviews, and these types of interviews were considered suitable since the purpose of the study is to gain a deeper understanding of how organizational and cultural differences may influence the adoption of digital operational tools in British firms. Semi-structured interviews also make it possible to ask follow-up questions that allow the participants to explain their experiences and opinions more freely if needed (Saunders et al., 2023).

The study has 8 interviews with participants from different professional backgrounds connected to operations, digitalization, and international business. Most participants were holding positions like managers, production leaders, logistics managers, operational excellence professionals, or representatives from SaaS companies. Some interviewees also work within areas like marketing or programming, these roles are not directly tied to operations, yet they are still relevant to the study since several participants have experience working with both Swedish and British companies and can provide insights into organizational culture and differences in working practices.

Most interviews have been conducted through Microsoft Teams due to the geographical distance between the researchers and the participants. The interviews lasted approximately 30–45 minutes, although some became slightly longer depending on the discussion and the experience of the participant.

A purposive sampling strategy was used in the study. This means that participants were selected based on their knowledge and relevance to the research topic rather than randomly (Saunders et al., 2023). The focus is therefore placed on individuals who have experience with digital operational tools, organizational management, or international business environments connected to Sweden or Britain.

The interview questions were connected to the theoretical framework presented in the literature review, where topics such as technology adoption, organizational culture, barriers to adoption, leadership, and differences between Swedish and British firms were therefore guiding the interviews. At the same time, the semi-structured format allowed flexibility during the conversation, which made it possible to explore unexpected perspectives or experiences that could become relevant during the interview process.

With permission from the participants, the interviews were recorded and later transcribed. This was done to ensure that the information is documented accurately and can be analyzed carefully during the later stages of the study.

3.5 Data Analysis

The empirical material in this study is analysed through thematic analysis. Thematic analysis is suitable for qualitative research because it helps researchers identify, organize and interpret patterns in interview material (Braun and Clarke, 2006). Since this thesis explores how cultural and organizational differences may influence the adoption of Swedish digital operational tools in the British market, this method is useful because it allows the study to compare answers across the interviews and identify recurring themes.

The analysis begins by transcribing the interviews and reading through the material carefully. This was done to become familiar with the respondents' answers before starting the coding process. Saunders et al. (2023) explain that qualitative data analysis requires the researcher to prepare, organize and interpret rich textual data in a systematic way. After the first reading, the material was divided into smaller sections for coding. During this stage, important parts of the interviews were marked with short labels that reflected what the respondents were talking about. The coding was done manually by reviewing the transcripts, identifying relevant passages and assigning descriptive codes based on their content. For example, statements about usability were coded as ease of use, while comments about management support were coded as leadership. Other codes related to training, digital readiness, data security, resistance, local presence, decision-making and cultural differences. This made it easier to work with the material in a structured way, while still keeping the meaning of the respondents' answers (Braun and Clarke, 2006).

To ensure that the analysis is systematic, all interview transcripts are considered in relation to each analytical category. This means that the researchers examine how each theme appears, or does not appear, across the full set of interviews rather than relying on only selected respondents for particular topics. This supports a more balanced interpretation of the empirical material.

The coding process is guided by the theoretical framework, but it also remains open to new themes from the interviews. This fits the study's theory-guided

approach, since existing theory is used as a starting point, while the empirical material may still reveal new patterns or explanations (Saunders et al., 2023). The analysis is mainly guided by TAM, TOE and CAGE. At the same time, the interview material is read with some openness, so that themes that were not expected from the beginning can still be noticed.

TAM is used to analyse how respondents describe the usefulness and ease of use. These concepts are relevant because technology acceptance is often connected to whether users perceive a system as useful and easy to use (Marikyan and Papagiannidis, 2025). In this study, this may include how respondents talk about digital operational tools in relation to daily operations, communication, overview, follow-up and decision-making.

TOE is used to analyse the organizational and technological conditions around adoption. In this thesis, this mainly includes leadership, training, system fit, internal support and organizational readiness. This is important because a digital operational tool can seem useful to users, but still be difficult to adopt if the organization does not have enough support, routines or resources in place (Oliveira et al., 2019).

CAGE is used to analyse how differences between Sweden and Britain may influence adoption. Ghemawat (2001) explains that the distance between countries can be cultural, administrative, geographic and economic. In this thesis, the focus is mainly placed on cultural and administrative distance, since these dimensions are closely connected to work practices, decision-making, regulations and local business expectations.

After the coding stage, similar codes are grouped into broader themes. For example, user-friendliness, training and confidence may be connected to ease of use, while leadership support, internal priorities and decision-making may be connected to organizational readiness. Comments about uncertainty, security concerns, lack of time or resistance may be understood as barriers. In contrast, clear value, internal support, training and a good fit with existing routines may be understood as facilitators. This follows the purpose of thematic analysis, where patterns are identified and interpreted in relation to the research aim (Braun and Clarke, 2006).

The final step is to connect the identified themes back to the research question and sub-questions. This means that the empirical material is not only described, but also interpreted in relation to the theoretical framework. By doing this, the analysis

can show how cultural and organizational differences may influence the adoption of Swedish digital operational tools in the British market.

An overview of the coding process, including examples of initial codes and how these were grouped into broader themes, is provided in Appendix 2.

3.6 Operationalization

Operationalization explains how the theoretical concepts in the study are translated into interview questions and later used in the analysis. Saunders et al. (2023) describe operationalization as the process of turning concepts into more concrete indicators that can be studied. In this thesis, this is important because adoption is not measured through numbers or statistical indicators. Instead, the study explores how adoption is understood and described by people with relevant experience of digital operational tools, organizational practices, internationalization and the British business context.

The interview guide is based on the main concepts from the literature review and the analytical framework, and is included in Appendix 1. TAM is used to understand how digital operational tools may be perceived by users and decision-makers. More specifically, the study focuses on perceived usefulness and perceived ease of use, since these concepts help explain why users may accept or resist information technology (Marikyan and Papagiannidis, 2025). In the interviews, this is explored through questions about what makes a digital operational tool valuable, what problems it may solve, and what could make it easy or difficult to use in daily operations.

The CAGE framework is used to understand how differences between Sweden and Britain may influence adoption. In the CAGE framework, Ghemawat (2001) describes country differences through four areas: cultural, administrative, geographic and economic distance. In this study, the focus is mainly placed on cultural and administrative distance, since these areas are closely related to work practices, decision-making, communication, regulations and market expectations. These concepts are explored through questions about differences between Swedish and British companies, how firms make decisions about new digital systems, and whether the British market creates specific challenges for the adoption of Swedish digital operational tools.

Organizational factors are also included because adoption does not depend only on the technology itself. A tool may be useful and easy to use, but implementation can still be affected by leadership, resources, training, internal readiness and employee attitudes. Oliveira et al. (2019) show that technology adoption is shaped by technological, organizational and environmental conditions. For this reason, the interview guide includes questions about current ways of working, management support, previous experience with digital operational tools and possible resistance.

The concepts of barriers and facilitators are used to connect the theoretical framework to the adoption process. Barriers refer to factors that may slow down or complicate adoption, such as lack of time, lack of knowledge, resistance, unclear value, limited resources or uncertainty. Facilitators refer to factors that may support adoption, such as clear usefulness, ease of use, leadership support, training, trust and a good fit with existing routines. These ideas are explored directly in the interviews by asking what could make companies hesitant to adopt digital operational tools, and what could make adoption more likely to succeed.

Through this operationalization, the interview questions are connected to the theoretical framework instead of being treated as separate from it. This creates a clear link between the literature review, the data collection and the later analysis. It also supports the structure of the study, since the same concepts that guide the interviews will later be used to interpret the empirical material.

The operationalization of the interview guide is summarized in Table 1. The table shows how the main concepts from the theoretical framework are connected to the interview questions and how these questions support the later analysis.

Table 1. Operationalization

Concept	Interview questions	Reasoning
Introduction and respondent background	1. To begin, could you briefly describe your role in the company and how your work connects to operations, planning, communication, or performance follow-up?	Used to understand the respondent's role, company context and connection to operations, planning, communication or performance follow-up.

Table 1. Operationalization

Concept	Interview questions	Reasoning
Current practices	2. Could you describe how operations and decision-making are usually organised in your company? 3. What tools do you currently use for planning, communication, and performance follow-up? 4. How is operational information usually shared and followed up on in the company? 5. How easy or difficult is it today to get a clear overview of what is happening in daily operations? 6. What parts of your current way of working function well, and what parts are more challenging?	Used to understand current routines for operations, decision-making, planning, communication and performance follow-up.
Adoption drivers	7. When your company considers a new digital system, what usually matters most in that decision? 8. What would make a digital operational tool useful in your daily work? 9. How important is it that a new digital tool is easy to use? 10. What do you think would make managers and employees more willing to start using a digital operational tool? 11. What benefits would you expect from replacing traditional tools, such as spreadsheets, whiteboards, or manual reporting, with a digital solution?	Connected to TAM, especially perceived usefulness and perceived ease of use. This section helps identify what makes a digital operational tool valuable and easy to adopt.

Table 1. Operationalization

Concept	Interview questions	Reasoning
Organizational factors	12. Who is usually involved when decisions are made about adopting new digital tools? 13. How ready would you say the company is to adopt new digital systems? 14. What role does leadership usually play when new tools or systems are introduced? 15. What type of training or support would employees need to feel comfortable using a new digital operational tool? 16. How important is internal communication when a new system is being implemented?	Focuses on internal conditions such as leadership, decision-making, digital readiness, training, support and internal communication.
Barriers and facilitators	17. In your experience, what usually makes people hesitant when a new system is introduced? 18. How easy or difficult is it to integrate a new digital tool into existing routines and ways of working? 19. Would there be any concerns about adopting a tool from an external SaaS provider? 20. What would make the adoption process easier for your company? 21. If you had to name the biggest barrier to adopting a digital operational tool, what would it be?	Used to identify what may slow down or support adoption, including hesitation, resistance, integration into routines and concerns about external SaaS providers.
Cross-country differences	22. Do you see any differences between Swedish and UK companies when it comes to	Connected to the CAGE framework and used to analyse how cultural, administrative, organizational and market-related differences

Table 1. Operationalization

Concept	Interview questions	Reasoning
	using digital tools in operations? 23. Do you see any cultural differences between Swedish and UK workplaces that may affect how new digital systems are received? 24. How would you compare decision-making processes in Swedish and UK companies? 25. Do you think UK companies may need a different type of support, training, or communication than Swedish companies when adopting digital tools? 26. How important do you think it is for a UK company that the software provider understands the local business culture or has a local presence?	between Sweden and the UK may influence adoption.

By connecting the theoretical concepts to the interview questions, the operationalization makes it easier to see how the study moves from theory to empirical findings and later analysis. It also helps keep the different parts of the thesis connected, instead of treating the theory, interviews and themes as separate parts.

3.7 Quality of Research

The quality of this study is discussed through validity and reliability. These concepts are often used to assess the quality of research and are also relevant in qualitative studies, although they need to be understood in relation to the purpose and design of the study (Saunders et al., 2023). Since this thesis is based on

qualitative interviews, the focus is not on statistical measurement, but on whether the research process is clear, careful and connected to the research question.

3.7.1 Validity

Validity is about whether the study actually examines what it set out to examine, and whether the findings can be linked back to the empirical material (Saunders et al., 2023). In this thesis, validity is addressed by using semi-structured interviews with respondents who have relevant knowledge of digital operational tools, organizational decision-making, internationalization or the British business context. The interview guide is also based on the theoretical framework, which helps ensure that the questions are connected to the research question and sub-questions.

Semi-structured interviews were useful for this study because they allowed the researchers to ask follow-up questions and clarify respondents' answers when needed. This was relevant since the study aims to understand how adoption is experienced in practice, and how cultural and organizational differences may influence that process (Saunders et al., 2023).

Validity is also supported through triangulation of perspectives (Carter et al., 2014). The empirical material includes respondents with different forms of relevant experience, including perspectives connected to digital operational tools, organizational use, international business and the British market. By comparing these perspectives, the study can examine whether similar themes appear across different respondents rather than relying on a single viewpoint. This strengthens the conclusions related to the British market, since the interpretation is supported by more than one type of perspective.

The study also has limitations in relation to validity. Since the study is based on selected respondents with relevant experience, the findings cannot be assumed to represent all Swedish providers of digital operational tools or all British firms. The respondents also speak from their own experiences, which means that the findings should be understood as contextual rather than universal. The purpose is therefore not to generalize statistically, but to provide a deeper understanding of how cultural and organizational differences may influence the adoption of Swedish digital operational tools in the British market.

3.7.2 Reliability

Reliability concerns whether the research process is consistent, transparent and possible to follow (Saunders et al., 2023). In qualitative research, exact replication can be difficult because interviews depend on context, interaction and interpretation. However, reliability can still be improved by clearly explaining how the data was collected and analysed.

Reliability is supported by using a semi-structured interview guide based on the theoretical framework. The same main themes guided the interviews, while the respondents still had room to explain their experiences in their own words. This gave the interviews a consistent structure, while also keeping the flexibility needed in qualitative research. The interview guide also helps ensure that the collected material can be connected back to the concepts used in the literature review.

Reliability is also supported by describing the analysis process clearly. The interviews are transcribed, read through, coded and grouped into broader themes. The interview material was considered in relation to the same analytical categories, which helped make the analysis more consistent. By explaining these steps, the study becomes more transparent and easier for the reader to follow. This also reduces the risk that the analysis appears disconnected from the empirical material.

3.8 Ethical Considerations

Ethical issues are crucial in this study since it is based on interviews with persons who shared their experiences, thoughts, and professional viewpoints. This resulted in the study meeting the ethical principles outlined by Saunders et al. (2023).

Participants received clear information about the purpose of the study and how the data would be collected, how the data would be utilized in the future, prior to each interview and that participants may drop out of the study at any time without giving a reason. Participation was completely voluntary.

Anonymity and confidentiality were strictly upheld during the research process because some participants might have given us some private company information, managerial techniques, or internal procedures. Participants' names, company information, and any other information that may reveal their identity would not be included in the final thesis if they would like to be anonymous.

The interviews were only recorded after consent had been received from the participants. All recordings and transcriptions were stored securely and were only accessible to the authors involved in the research project. The collected material was not shared outside the study and was only used for academic purposes connected to this thesis.

In order to strengthen the credibility and trustworthiness of the research, the study was compared to perspectives from several participants working in different organizations and roles. Looking at many perspectives allows you to uncover similarities and contrasts across firms while also lowering the danger of the analysis being overly reliant on one specific perspective. The result of this was a more comprehensive and balanced grasp of the research issue.

3.9 Author Contributions

This thesis was written by three authors who collaborated throughout the research process, each contributing to the study's design and ideation. The theoretical foundation, formulating the research questions, collecting empirical data, and analyzing the collected data were all discussed and worked on together by the writers. The writers worked together while discussing the form of the thesis, methodological choices, and the overall direction of the study to ensure a consistent and shared understanding of the research subject.

Although certain tasks and sections were divided between the authors during different stages of the writing process, the work was carried out in close collaboration. All authors participated in reviewing, discussing, and revising the different parts of the thesis continuously throughout the project. The final version of the thesis was therefore reviewed and approved collectively by all three authors before submission.

4. Empirical Findings

4.1 Introduction to the Empirical Findings

This chapter presents the interview data collected in Sweden and Britain. It looks at how industrial companies move from manual routines to digital platforms. To make the findings easier to follow, these were systematically categorized into three themes through a qualitative thematic analysis, which was directly guided by the dimensions established in the analytical framework. The first covers how individual users see the tool and the friction that appears on the shop floor. The second looks at organizational readiness and how leadership handles the adoption process. The third deals with cultural friction between the two countries and what that means for market adaptation. Together, these sections show how user level behavior, the company structures, and national differences interact. Comparing Sweden's collaborative style with the more hierarchical and accountability driven environment found in Britain.

4.2 User Perceptions and Operational Friction

4.2.1 Perceived Usefulness and Real-Time Visibility

Our empirical findings reveal that the perceived usefulness of digital operational tools is highly dependent on how effectively the system replaces traditional manual tracking and creates immediate visibility across different levels of the company. When examining the transition from physical whiteboards and manual Excel sheets to a digital platform, a clear contrast emerges between the operational expectations of Swedish and British users.

Starting with the Swedish side, the tool is primarily seen as a mechanism to streamline already existing communication routines and centralize metrics. From the perspective of the Swedish manufacturing sector, production and operations managers emphasize that the digital boards allow teams to instantly visualize daily targets directly on the shop floor. Respondent B, who is a Swedish production manager, highlighted this operational convenience by explaining how the system enables visibility across multiple geographic locations: *“from site A to site B, that you can see the two different sites directly from leadership level... just that there is*

an opportunity to be able to control all different types of company figures." This immediate access to data eliminates the need for manual updates and prevents information from being trapped in isolated spreadsheets. Respondent A, the Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of the software provider, supported this domestic perspective, explaining that the core design philosophy of the system was precisely to eliminate physical whiteboard limitations: *"We have affected our administration, definitely... we try to keep the highest possible standard technically."* By digitizing these flows, Swedish users find utility in the structural connectivity that the software brings to daily operations.

On the British side, however, British users evaluate the usefulness of the digital tool through a lens more focused on strategic accountability, decision-making, and commercial efficiency. The respondents from the United Kingdom agree that the real-time tracking feature is a major advantage, but they emphasize its value as a tool to justify investments and monitor performance across departments. For example, Respondent E, a former CEO within the British media sector, mentioned that a digital tool is deemed useful only if it can directly connect daily operational outputs with larger corporate goals, stating: *"My job connected with operations... because at the end of the day, you have to look at the figures, you have to look at how many outputs did you sell, what was the cost... everything is connected."* In addition, Respondent G, representing a British corporate environment, notes that having a digitized platform provides a critical *"single source of truth"*, helping them to prevent different teams from presenting conflicting data during their administrative meetings.

Similarly, Respondent H, a project manager in the British engineering sector, stresses that real-time visibility is highly valued because it allows managers to detect bottlenecks instantly and take immediate corrective actions, which is essential in a fast-paced environment. Respondent H further emphasized that ensuring operational clarity is closely tied to the support structure, noting: *"It is very important... local understanding obviously helps build trust and improves communication during the implementation."* Consequently, while Swedish users appreciate the tool for its daily administrative convenience and team alignment, British users place a higher value on its ability to enforce operational transparency and strategic control.

4.2.2 The Generational Gap and Perceived Ease of Use

In this section, our empirical evidence highlights that the perceived ease of use of a newly introduced digital tool is heavily influenced by a generational gap and the varying levels of digital familiarity among the workforce. Both Swedish and the British respondents note that, while younger employees tend to intuit and embrace the software almost immediately, on the other hand, older staff members and traditional managers frequently exhibit a higher degree of initial friction, requiring customized onboarding approaches.

Within the Swedish context, this challenge is identified across different organizational levels, from the production floors to the management positions, where resistance often stems directly from an individual's historical digital habits rather than an objective flaw in the platform. Respondent C, a Swedish operations development manager, observed this demographic friction within leadership ranks, noting: *"The one who is most hesitant of the managers is a couple of years younger than me. It is about what you have for familiarity to work [with digital systems]."* To counteract this friction and simplify the user interface for staff members with lower digital confidence, Swedish manufacturing firms heavily emphasize operational support rather than mandatory pressure. Respondent B, a Swedish production manager, highlighted that simplicity is achieved by providing hands-on, localized guidance directly on the shop floor, stating: *"It feels secure for (the workers) to know that there is someone in the country who can actually come... to show them how to use it."* This indicates that even in highly digitized environments, ease of use is structurally linked to close-range troubleshooting and personalized reassurance.

While in the British market, the generational gap manifests as a prominent operational barrier that directly influences the speed of the implementation process, as older employees accustomed to physical routines perceive digital tracking as more complex and less intuitive. Respondent E, reflecting on corporate transformations in the United Kingdom, explicitly tied the ease of adoption to the demographic profile of the organization, stating, *"It is about age. If you are 20, 25, 30 years old, you learn tech very quickly. If you are 55 or 60, it takes longer."* To counteract this technological friction and build confidence among users who are less tech-savvy, customized assistance becomes mandatory. Respondent H, a project manager in Britain, reinforced this by stating that the software's ease of use

is only secured when the provider bridges this capability gap through continuous support, noting that the provider: *"...can offer quick support if basically any issues come up."* Therefore, across both nations, the generational gap represents a universal hurdle where the perceived complexity of the software decreases only when organizations actively manage the user's digital familiarity gap.

4.2.3 Fear of Monitoring and Operational Disruption

Another significant factor shaping user perceptions is the friction caused by the fear of constant supervision and the potential disruption of the established daily workflows. When a digital platform standardizes data output, the employees do not always perceive it as an efficiency tool. Instead, it can be viewed as an intrusive mechanism for surveillance or an unnecessary administrative hurdle that breaks their operational peace. This initial doubt is particularly visible during the early stages of implementation, where the shift from private, and localized tracking to a full corporate visibility creates a cultural shock for the workforce.

In the British corporate environment, this indecision is deeply tied to rigid accountability structures. Where real-time tracking can trigger anxiety among the staff members, who feel constantly examined by upper management. Rather than entering data naturally, employees may delay or over-analyze their inputs. Respondent G emphasized that in traditionally highly competitive sectors, employees fear that putting all figures on an open platform leaves no room for operational variance, noting: *"The caution comes from how deep the internal information goes... people are careful about what they share when everything is visible."* This indicates that digital transparency can backfire if users believe the software is being used as a disciplinary tool rather than a supportive one. To build user confidence and prevent immediate resistance, Respondent H mentioned that, in this case, the fear must be addressed through transparent deployment strategies, emphasizing the need for: *"...making sure they don't feel like it's just another tool to watch over them."*

On the Swedish side, the corporate culture tends to be less top-down and more driven by consensus. Operational disruption remains a prominent concern. In this context, the friction occurs particularly when a digital system threatens to complicate simple, hands-on practices that have worked for years. Respondent B, a Swedish production manager, explained that floor workers often prefer physical, tangible routines, like writing on a physical board, over logging into a screen, because they view the physical board as a safe, localized tool. They fear the new

technology will slow down their manual output and add unnecessary administrative steps: *"...they want to know that the system is not going to stand in the way of their actual job."* Furthermore, Respondent C, a Swedish operations development manager, supported this by stating that resistance occurs when a new platform is forced upon an existing ecosystem without showing immediate personal benefits, noting that if a tool complicates their established peace: *"...if it feels harder than the old way, they will just avoid it."* Therefore, across both national contexts, the fear of being overly monitored or operationally disrupted acts as a strong barrier that directly decreases the software's perceived ease of use.

4.2.4 The Role of 'Superusers' and Hands-on Training

To successfully mitigate operational friction, reduce the fear of monitoring, and to overcome the generational gap, our empirical data points to the critical role of internal "superusers" and hands-on training. Rather than relying solely on external software providers or distant IT departments, both Swedish and British organizations emphasize that adoption rates increase significantly when internal employees champion the digital transition. These "superusers" act as a vital bridge for their organization by translating technical software features into practical and everyday business value for the rest of the staff.

In the British market, the approach to training and user support tends to be highly structured as well as strictly scheduled. British respondents note that designating specific project leaders to act as formal intermediaries between the software provider and the end-users is essential to building trust and ensuring compliance. Respondent F, an operations director and integration lead in Britain, explained that, without these designated figures, the workforce often rejects the system. Noting that training sessions must be continuous and closely monitored to ensure long-term usage, rather than just a one-time event: *"It is an ongoing process. You can't just drop the system on them and walk away. You need internal champions who check in every week. You need someone on the inside who actually understands the local routines... if the push only comes from the software vendor, the staff will just see it as another IT imposition."* This highly structured approach ensures that the digital tool is formally integrated into the corporate workflow and that no employee is left behind due to a lack of technical skills.

On the contrary, in the Swedish context, the concept of a superuser is applied in a

much more informal, peer-to-peer manner directly on the shop floor, aligning with their flat organizational structures. Respondent D, a Swedish continuous improvement manager, highlighted that the floor workers respond best to training when it comes from a familiar, equal colleague rather than a top-tier manager. This approach creates a psychologically safe environment for learning. As the manager mentioned, *"It works best when it is one of their own showing them how to click and navigate... it removes the prestige and makes it okay to ask stupid questions."* This indicates that Swedish firms rely heavily on lateral support and localized, highly practical guidance to ease the digital transition.
Therefore, whether through structured British project leads or informal Swedish peer training, the presence of dedicated internal superusers acts as a decisive and mandatory factor in securing the platform's perceived ease of use and, in addition, long-term acceptance.

4.3 Organizational Readiness and Leadership Dynamics

This section focuses on how organizational readiness and leadership dynamics influence the adoption of digital operational tools. Across the interviews, the respondents described adoption as more than a technical decision. They connected adoption to managerial support, employee involvement, system integration, security requirements, and the resources available during implementation. The section is structured around four subthemes: executive mandates and bottom-up engagement, strategic alignment with existing IT, security and confidentiality, and resource allocation during rollout.

4.3.1 Executive Mandates vs. Bottom-Up Engagement

Leadership was described as an important part of adopting digital operational tools. However, the interviews also show that leadership alone is not enough. Several respondents explained that managers need to support the implementation clearly, while employees also need to understand the purpose of the system and how it connects to their daily work.

Respondent A explained that successful implementation often depends on having active people inside the customer organization who understand what they want to achieve with the tool. At the same time, the respondent described that the provider places a large part of the implementation process in the customer's hands, since the customer needs to be involved when deciding which information should be

included on the digital boards and how the boards should be used in daily work. This presents adoption as a process that requires both provider support and active involvement from the customer organization.

This was also visible among the Swedish user firms. Respondent B described leadership as important after a system has been introduced, since managers need to continue asking for information from the system. If leaders do not follow up on the information, employees may stop updating it because they do not see why it matters. Respondent C also explained that managers have an important role in bringing the change closer to the working groups. According to this respondent, a digital tool may work during a project phase, but if managers do not continue to show that it is important, the use of the system may lose momentum over time.

Respondent D described a similar issue from another perspective. The respondent explained that a previous digital initiative had not worked well when it was mainly pushed from higher management. In that case, the system was introduced from above and pushed out to employees, but the engagement from the employees was not strong enough. The respondent therefore described that energy and motivation also need to come from below, while management still needs to clearly know where the organization is heading.

The British respondents also stressed the role of leadership. Respondent E explained that leadership is important because managers guide the organization toward tools that can make work more efficient. The respondent also described that change can be uncomfortable, which makes it important for leaders to give confidence and keep the organization aligned. Respondent F explained that digital initiatives are often driven by directors, partners, or people with senior authority, and that these people have influence when new tools are considered. Respondent G also stated that leadership plays a vital role because employees often look to managers during changes. According to this respondent, managers need to explain what is being introduced, what benefits it brings, and how it affects daily work. Respondent H added that internal communication is important before a change takes place, since employees need to know what is happening and why.

The Swedish respondents mainly described leadership as important for keeping the system active after implementation. The British respondents placed more emphasis on leadership as a way to reduce uncertainty before and during change. In both markets, leadership mattered, but the role of managers was described in slightly different ways.

4.3.2 Strategic Alignment and Integration with Existing IT

Another issue that came up several times in the interviews was that digital operational tools need to match the organization's existing systems and routines. The respondents did not describe adoption as only a question of whether the tool works on its own. Instead, they often connected successful adoption to whether the tool can be introduced into the company's current technical environment and everyday ways of working.

Respondent A explained that the technical setup of the platform is connected to systems that many customer organizations already use, such as Microsoft and Azure. This was described as an advantage, since many companies already work within Microsoft-based environments. From this perspective, the tool becomes easier to introduce when it does not feel separate from the systems that are already used in the organization.

Among the Swedish user firms, integration was also connected to daily follow-up and operational routines. Respondent C described digital production boards as part of the company's broader work with daily management and production follow-up. The respondent explained that the company already uses systems such as i-Planner and M3, while digital production boards are used in the daily reporting structure. This shows that new digital tools need to fit into existing routines for planning, communication, and performance follow-up.

Respondent D also described the use of several tools in the current work process, including Excel, Power BI, and a digital visual management tool for showing the operational situation. The respondent explained that the tool is used to create transparency around areas such as safety, quality, delivery, and staffing. This indicates that digital tools are seen as valuable when they support existing follow-up structures and make operational information easier to access and understand.

The British respondents described similar concerns, but with a stronger focus on system compatibility and technical coordination. Respondent E explained that a digital operational tool needs to be functional, allow standardization across different locations, and integrate with other company systems so that information can be consolidated. This shows that system fit was connected not only to daily use, but also to the organization's ability to compare and coordinate information across different parts of the company.

Respondent F also described the importance of internal IT support when new systems are introduced. In this respondent's organization, a specific team is

responsible for communicating new technology, giving access to systems, and helping employees when they do not know how to use certain functions. However, the respondent also pointed out that using a system fully can become difficult if employees do not have enough time to learn all of its functions. This shows that technical fit is not only about the system itself, but also about whether employees have the time and support needed to use it properly.

Respondents G and H both connected integration to existing workflows. Respondent G explained that several departments are usually involved when digital tools are introduced, including production managers, operations managers, IT, finance, and senior management. The respondent also explained that the tool needs to be practical for the people who will use it in daily operations. Respondent H described a similar issue and explained that integration can be complicated when a company already uses several systems that do not work well together. According to this respondent, a new tool is easier to adopt when it is flexible and can fit with existing systems or workloads without requiring major changes immediately.

4.3.3 Security, Confidentiality, and ISO Certifications

Security and confidentiality also came up as important factors in the adoption of digital operational tools. The respondents connected this mainly to trust, sensitive information, and the risks that may appear when an external provider is introduced into the organization's digital environment.

Respondent A explained that customers often have many IT security questions before the provider can be approved as a secure supplier. The respondent described this as an important part of the adoption process, especially when working with larger customer organizations. The respondent also explained that the platform aims to maintain a high technical and IT security standard, which becomes important when customers evaluate whether the tool can be trusted.

Among the Swedish user firms, security was also mentioned as a factor that could make organizations hesitant toward external providers. Respondent B explained that data-related issues and security requirements can create barriers when new digital tools are considered. The respondent also mentioned that external providers may need to sign an NDA and that the security aspect can become one of the most important factors in the decision. This shows that the adoption of a digital tool is

not only about functionality, but also about whether the organization feels safe sharing or managing information through the system.

Respondent D also connected security to credibility. The respondent explained that ISO certification would make a provider more trustworthy, especially in an international or British market context. The respondent described certification as a strong advantage and mentioned that data-related aspects, such as production figures, sales information, and orders, often need to be checked carefully. From this perspective, certification becomes a way to reduce uncertainty and strengthen trust in the provider.

The British respondents described similar concerns, but often in relation to external risk and data protection. Respondent E explained that companies need to be cautious when adopting tools from external software providers, especially because of risks connected to spying, cyberattacks, viruses, and blackmail. The respondent described this as particularly important for larger companies that handle large amounts of information. This indicates that security concerns can become a direct barrier if the organization does not fully trust the provider or the system.

Respondent F raised the issue of confidentiality from a professional service perspective. The respondent explained that hesitation can appear when a digital tool handles client-sensitive data in a way that feels outside the firm's control. The respondent also stated that adoption would be smoother if the tool followed the firm's compliance and data privacy protocols from the start. In this case, the system would need to feel suitable for a law-firm environment and respect the high level of confidentiality involved in the work.

Respondents G and H also connected trust to formal certifications. Respondent G described certifications as essential and explained that without certification, adoption would likely not move forward. Respondent H similarly stated that ISO certification and GDPR-related credibility would increase trust in an external system provider. These responses show that formal standards can function as reassurance when organizations assess whether a provider is reliable enough.

4.3.4 Resource Allocation and the Phased Rollout

The interviews also show that adoption depends on the resources and structure available during implementation. The respondents described digital adoption as something that requires time, support, planning, and a realistic pace. It was not

presented as something that can simply be decided and introduced without preparation.

Respondent A explained that implementation support is part of the provider's work with customers. The respondent described that the process can vary depending on the customer and the type of package they use. At the same time, the respondent emphasized that implementation should not become too large or complicated from the beginning. Instead, the customer can start small, try the system in practice, and then build on it together with the provider. This presents adoption as a gradual process where the tool is adjusted over time rather than fully completed from the start.

Among the Swedish user firms, Respondent B also connected implementation to planning and structure. The respondent explained that a clear project plan, clear deadlines, and clear escalation levels would make the implementation process easier. The respondent also described that implementation can become difficult when many people and several parts of the organization are involved. This shows that organizational readiness is not only about willingness to adopt, but also about having a structured process for how the implementation should move forward.

Respondent B also highlighted the importance of having a long-term plan for the system. The respondent explained that if a system is only used occasionally, it may not be worth spending time and money on training employees. In that case, employees may also struggle to understand why they should use it. This suggests that resources used for implementation need to be connected to a clear and continuous purpose.

The British respondents described similar issues, especially in relation to time, cost, and gradual implementation. Respondent E explained that organizations need to be careful when making IT investments. The respondent stated that it is often better to invest in something that already exists and has proven to work, since developing something new can take longer, become more expensive, and perform worse than expected. This shows that cost and implementation risk are part of how organizations evaluate new digital systems.

Respondent F also described time as an important factor. The respondent explained that some systems have many functions, but that employees may not have enough time to learn all of them. In this case, the difficulty was not only whether the system existed or worked, but whether employees had enough time in their daily work to understand and use it properly. This shows that employees need both internal support and enough time to learn the system during adoption.

Respondents G and H both emphasized the value of introducing new systems gradually. Respondent G explained that a phased implementation approach would be helpful, together with stronger training and clear communication. Respondent H described a similar view and stated that a phased rollout would give employees more time to adjust instead of introducing all changes at once. The respondent also mentioned that pilot projects or smaller implementations could help employees become familiar with the system step by step.

The findings in this theme show that organizational readiness is built through several practical conditions: leadership, system fit, internal support, security, and enough time during implementation. Both the Swedish and British respondents described adoption as something that has to fit into existing work, not as a tool that can simply be added from the outside. The Swedish respondents mainly connected readiness to daily production routines, managerial follow-up and practical use on the shop floor. The British respondents placed more emphasis on system compatibility, IT support, time to learn the system and gradual implementation. This suggests that readiness is not only about being positive toward a digital tool, but also about having the structure, people and resources needed to make it work in practice.

The next theme therefore, moves beyond internal readiness and looks at the wider cross-country context, especially decision-making, trust-building and digital maturity in the British market.

4.4 Cultural Friction and Cross-Border Market Adaptation

This section presents findings related to how organizational structures, cultural differences, and operational environments may influence the implementation of digital operational tools across different markets. The differences that came to light due to the interviews connect decision-making structures, administrative routines, communication patterns, trust building, and levels of digital maturity within organizations. Together, these findings provide insight into how cross-border and organizational factors may affect the adoption and implementation of digital operational systems in different operational contexts.

4.4.1 Decision-Making Styles: Hierarchical vs. Flat Structures

Several respondents described differences in how decision-making and operational coordination are structured within organizations. While both Swedish and British firms relied on operational meetings, reporting systems, and managerial

follow-ups, differences could still be identified regarding hierarchy, communication flows, and how decisions were implemented in practice.

Respondents from the United Kingdom often described decision-making structures as more hierarchical, particularly regarding strategic decisions and implementation processes. One British production manager explained that strategic decisions were usually made by senior management, while day-to-day operational discussions were handled by supervisors and production managers at the plant level. At the same time, the respondent described the structure as collaborative despite the hierarchy, since communication still occurred across multiple operational levels.

This structure of hierarchical nature was also visible in another interview with a respondent who had experience managing operations across several international markets. The respondent explained that offices that operated locally were required to report operational and financial performance back to headquarters. In this matter, specific standardized systems and reporting structures were used. Due to this, most of the decision making regarding strategic decisions, investments, and operational changes were largely approved centrally. Headquarters could still enforce the implementation of new systems or operational changes even if some local offices disagreed with management decisions.

At the same time, respondents from Swedish manufacturing environments described organizational structures that combined centralized strategic direction with operational involvement across several levels of the organization. One respondent spoke about the global and regional management levels that provided strategic targets and goals. These goals were later on translated down through team leaders and operational departments. Another respondent spoke about the operational information and what issues within production could be communicated through several organizational levels. The usage of visual management systems and digital dashboards allows problems from production lines to move upward within the organization when necessary.

The interviews also showed that Swedish organizations often emphasized visibility, transparency, and employee involvement within operational management processes. Respondents frequently referred to digital visual boards, shared access to operational information, and daily meetings where production performance and operational deviations could be followed in real time. One respondent explained that employees had broad access to operational dashboards and could monitor performance and operational status directly through the system.

In addition, some respondents connected decision-making structures to employees' openness toward digital systems. One respondent explained that implementation challenges sometimes emerged when certain individuals were uncomfortable using digital operational tools, which affected operational routines and implementation processes. This suggests that decision-making structures alone were not the only important factor, since employee attitudes and digital familiarity could also influence how operational systems were adopted within organizations.

In the end, the findings indicate that both Swedish and British organizations relied on structured operational management systems. Differences could still be identified regarding hierarchy, centralization, and operational involvement. British respondents generally described more centralized decision-making structures, while Swedish respondents placed greater emphasis on operational transparency, visual management, and shared involvement across organizational levels.

4.4.2 Administrative Distance and Compliance

Administrative structures were another recurring theme identified in the interviews. Compliance requirements and standardized operational processes during the implementation of digital operational tools were highlighted by multiple respondents. The description of how reporting structures, approval systems, and organizational requirements were repeatedly mentioned, respondents delved deep into how everything could influence new digital systems, how they were introduced and adopted within organizations.

Respondents who came from bigger firms were repeatedly highlighting the value of uniform reporting and centralized operating systems. One responder was using a unified reporting system to keep track of specific operational performance in many offices overseas. In order for this to work, all units were required to report in the same format. The same responder explained how procedures were required to effectively compare operational performance across locations and markets.

Just like that, some respondents who came from manufacturing environments described how operational information was integrated through ERP systems, dashboards, and centralized reporting structures. One respondent focused a lot on operational planning, production data, and reporting systems and explained that they were connected through a central data hub. This allowed information to be visualized through dashboards and reporting tools across the organization. Another respondent described how operational information and KPI follow-ups were

shared through digital systems, meetings, and automated reporting structures that supported communication between departments and management levels.

The interviews also showed that compliance requirements and organizational control structures could affect implementation processes. Several respondents highlighted the importance of standardized operational procedures, particularly when organizations operated across multiple locations or countries. One respondent explained that operational systems had to align with organizational standards, reporting requirements, and existing structures in order to function effectively within the company.

In addition, respondents described situations where implementation processes became more complicated due to existing systems, multiple reporting platforms, or organizational routines. One respondent explained that employees often worked across several operational systems simultaneously, making it difficult to maintain visibility and consistency across different operational activities. Another respondent explained that information was sometimes spread across several systems, spreadsheets, and reporting tools, which could slow down operational decision-making processes.

The findings also show how organizations that possess higher levels of operational standardization and digital integration seem to have a clearer structure for follow-ups and operational visibility. At the same time, respondents were suggesting that administrative requirements, reporting procedures, and existing organizational systems may create complexity during the implementation process. Especially when the new digital operational tool is focused on being implemented into an already established operational environment.

Taken together, the findings indicate that organizations operating across multiple sites and departments often depend on structured reporting systems, centralized procedures, and standardized operational processes. While these structures may improve coordination and operational control, they may also create additional challenges when new digital operational tools are introduced into already established organizational environments.

4.4.3 The Importance of Local Presence and Trust Building

Several respondents highlighted that the successful implementation of digital operational tools depended heavily on trust, communication, and employee involvement within the organization. Even when the systems themselves were viewed positively, respondents explained that implementation processes became more successful when employees understood the purpose behind the system and felt included in the operational work.

One respondent thought about the operational performance, improvements, and the effects of their own work through digital visual boards and operational dashboards. The engagement of the employees increased when they could clearly see the connection between the work and the system. From another aspect, one respondent spoke about shared operational information. Visual management systems create greater transparency between departments and make communication easier during day to day operations.

The interviews also showed that organizations were often more open toward digital operational systems when the tools supported already existing operational routines rather than replacing them completely. One respondent explained that employees generally responded more positively when the digital system strengthened current ways of working instead of forcing major operational changes.

At the same time, several respondents emphasized the importance of continuous communication during implementation processes. Operational meetings, daily follow-ups, and shared reporting systems were described as important ways of maintaining coordination and reducing uncertainty within production environments.

Some respondents also suggested that trust toward the system developed gradually over time. Employees became more comfortable using digital operational tools when they received support, guidance, and clear explanations regarding how the system could help their operational work. This appeared to reduce resistance and create stronger acceptance toward digital operational systems inside the organization.

In the end, findings highlight trust, communication, and employee involvement. These play an important role during the implementation of digital operational

tools. The transparency of an organization and the involvement of employees with the implementation process show that it will make the adoption stronger and make workers' acceptance of digital operational systems faster.

4.4.4 Digital Maturity and the Push for Efficiency

A pattern that is always recurring in the interviews was the growing interest in digital maturity. Furthermore, respondents were quick to highlight the operational efficiency and the need for improved visibility within organizations. The observation of the importance of digital operational tools was often introduced to simplify communication, improve operational follow-ups, and create a clearer overview. This is very relevant to an organization's daily management.

Many respondents described how organizations were gradually moving away from manual routines, spreadsheets, and traditional reporting methods toward more visual and integrated digital systems. One respondent explained that the organization was currently transitioning from older production planning methods toward Power BI solutions and digital operational boards in order to improve visibility and planning processes across production activities. Another respondent explained that operational information had previously been spread across several different systems and reporting tools, making coordination and follow-ups more difficult.

Several respondents also described that digital operational tools made operational management more transparent within the organization. Employees and managers could monitor quality, delivery performance, safety, and production deviations in real time through shared dashboards and visual management systems. According to one respondent, this visibility made it easier to identify operational problems early and understand where additional focus or resources were needed.

As the interviews continued, the realization became very clear. Organizations that have higher levels of digital maturity often emphasized integration between systems and operational platforms. One respondent argued that operational systems became more effective when information from several subsystems could be gathered into one shared platform. If everything can be gathered in one place, it would make the daily management work much simpler in the long run. If this is

done correctly, employees could easily switch between different systems and simplify operational coordination within the organization.

At the same time, respondents explained that digital maturity varied significantly between organizations, departments, and individuals. While some employees adapted quickly to digital dashboards and visual reporting systems, others were more comfortable with traditional operational methods. One respondent described how implementation challenges sometimes appeared when certain employees were unfamiliar with digital tools or hesitant toward technological changes in operational work. Another respondent explained that organizations sometimes struggled to balance older operational systems with newer digital platforms during transition periods, which occasionally created confusion and inefficiencies in operational reporting processes.

In addition, several respondents connected digital operational tools directly to efficiency improvements within production and operational environments. Real-time visibility, automated reporting, and shared operational information were described as important ways of improving coordination, reducing delays, and simplifying operational follow-ups. Respondents explained that digital systems allowed operational issues to be identified and escalated faster compared to traditional manual reporting methods.

Some respondents also highlighted the importance of digital operational tools as organizations expanded across multiple departments or locations. Shared digital systems created more consistent reporting structures and improved operational visibility across different parts of the organization. As it appeared, coordination will be easier, especially in larger environments where several operational teams need the same access to the same operational information simultaneously.

As a summary, the findings present the idea of organizations increasingly viewing digital operational tools as important for improving efficiency. Daily activities are important and would need a facilitator to increase operational visibility, and coordination between workers and sections in an organization. However, the interviews also present another point of view where the digital maturity within the organization could influence how easily employees adapted to new systems. This means, all in all, that the implementation processes often depend on both technological readiness and employee familiarity with digital ways of working.

5. Analysis

5.1 Introduction to the Analysis

This chapter analyses the empirical findings in relation to the theoretical framework presented in the literature review. The purpose is to understand how organizational and cultural differences between Sweden and Britain influence the adoption of digital operational tools in British firms. To avoid a sequential evaluation, the analysis applies an integrated lens where macro-level cross-country distances (CAGE) actively shape firm-level organizational readiness and leadership styles (TOE). These structural company conditions, in turn, directly dictate the micro-level user perceptions of usefulness, ease of use, and monitoring anxiety within the Technology Acceptance Model (TAM). The analysis is built continuously around these core areas identified in the empirical data and demonstrates how national, corporate, and individual levels complement and influence one another throughout the cross-border adoption process.

5.2 Theme 1: User Perceptions and Operational Friction

The live data visibility means different things, depending on the national context. In Sweden, its value is tied to plant level connectivity and the ability to see figures across sites in real-time, which fits the high digital intensity of Swedish SMEs (European Commission, 2025b). In Britain, the same feature is interpreted as a tool for financial oversight and centralized control. This contrast matters because it shows that perceived usefulness (TAM) is not inherent to the software; it is constructed by the local corporate environment and cultural distance (CAGE). For a Swedish provider entering Britain, marketing the tool as a platform for open coordination will not work. Instead, the value proposition must be reframed around strategic control and compliance to match what British managers actually need.

The ease of use is also shaped by context. In Sweden, the age gap in digital skills is handled locally through direct support in the production area, which reduces the friction and improves the perceived ease of use (Wang et al., 2025). In Britain, the same generational gap acts as a hard barrier. Older workers used to whiteboards see digital entry as a burden, and the national skills gap (UK Department for

Business & Trade, 2026) makes this worse. The implication is clear: a Swedish provider cannot assume a uniform baseline of digital literacy. Without investing in structured capability building (TOE) before deployment, the software will feel too complex for a large part of the British workforce, and adoption will stall.

Monitoring anxiety adds another layer. In Britain, live visibility triggers fear of surveillance. The staff see dashboards as a way for management to monitor them, which leads to over-checking, delayed entries, or active resistance. In Sweden, operators reject digital screens for a different reason: typing feels slower than writing on a whiteboard, and they have enough autonomy to bypass tools that slow them down. This difference matters because it changes the implementation strategy. In Britain, managers must explicitly separate real-time data from disciplinary decisions to rebuild trust and lower the high-power distance friction (CAGE). In Sweden, the priority should be making the interface faster and more ergonomic.

Superusers and hands on training are the most effective responses in both contexts, but they need to look different. In Britain, legacy structures and skill gaps mean the training cannot be a single event (UK Department for Business & Trade, 2026). Firms need continuous programs with the internal project leads who validate the system and push back against inertia, proving that organizational readiness (TOE) must be formalized. In Sweden, the same function works informally through peer-based learning within the working teams, where operators can ask basic questions without judgment. This means a uniform training strategy will fail. Providers must adapt their support model to fit the organizational structure of each market.

5.3 Theme 2: Organizational Readiness and Leadership Dynamics

The empirical findings show that organizational readiness is an important condition for the adoption of digital operational tools. The respondents did not describe adoption as only a technical decision, but as something that also depends on leadership, employee involvement, system integration, security requirements and the resources available during implementation. This fits with the TOE framework, where adoption is influenced by technological, organizational and environmental conditions (Oliveira et al., 2019). In this study, the organizational

side becomes especially important, since digital operational tools need to become part of daily routines rather than remain separate technical solutions.

Leadership was one of the clearest organizational factors in the findings. Several respondents described that managers need to support the implementation and explain why the system is being introduced. This supports Oyetade et al. (2024), who highlight leadership, organizational culture and resource availability as important internal factors in ICT adoption. The findings also show that leadership alone is not enough. A tool may be introduced from the top, but if employees do not understand the purpose or feel involved, the adoption process may still become weak. This was visible in the example where a previous digital initiative had not worked well when it was mainly pushed from higher management. Therefore, leadership should not only be understood as formal decision-making authority, but also as the ability to create understanding, motivation and involvement in the organization.

This also connects to TAM, although the focus of this section is mainly organizational. TAM explains that users are more likely to accept a system when they perceive it as useful and easy to use (Marikyan and Papagiannidis, 2025). The findings suggest that these perceptions are partly shaped by the organization. If managers communicate the purpose of the tool clearly and connect it to daily work, the system is more likely to be seen as meaningful. If the tool is mainly presented as another system to update, the value may become unclear. This shows that SaaS adoption is not only about the system itself, but also about whether the organization helps users understand why the tool matters in practice (Oliveira et al., 2019). In this way, employee acceptance and organizational readiness are closely connected.

The findings also show that strategic alignment and integration with existing IT are important for adoption. Several respondents described that digital operational tools need to fit with current systems, workflows and reporting structures. This reflects Oliveira et al. (2019), who argue that SaaS adoption depends not only on the technology itself, but also on internal organizational conditions and the wider context in which the firm operates. A technically strong system may still create problems if it does not fit the systems and routines that already exist. In the empirical findings, the Swedish respondents often connected integration to daily follow-up and operational routines, while the British respondents placed more emphasis on compatibility, standardization and coordination between departments. This indicates that adoption becomes easier when the tool supports existing work rather than creating extra layers of reporting.

Security and confidentiality also appear as important conditions for organizational readiness. The findings show that organizations may hesitate to adopt tools from external providers when sensitive information, client data or operational figures are involved. This makes security more than a technical issue. It becomes part of whether the organization is willing to trust the provider and allow the system into its daily operations. In the findings, ISO certification, GDPR-related credibility and compliance were described as important signals of trust. This suggests that formal standards can reduce uncertainty and make adoption feel safer, especially in organizations where confidentiality is important. For Swedish digital operational tools entering the British market, this becomes relevant because trust must be established before the tool can be accepted as part of the organization's work.

Resources and rollout structure were also central in the findings. Respondents described that adoption requires time, training, support and clear planning. This supports Oyetade et al. (2024), who include resource availability and employee attitudes as important internal factors in ICT adoption. It also connects to Aljaraidah (2026), who argues that organizations that invest in training and support usually face fewer adoption problems. The findings show that even when a system is useful, employees may struggle to use it if they do not have enough time to learn its functions. A phased rollout can therefore work as a facilitator, since it allows the organization to start smaller, test the system and build confidence gradually.

These findings are also relevant for understanding the adoption of Swedish digital operational tools in the British market. The empirical material indicates that the British respondents placed particular emphasis on system compatibility, standardization, compliance and clear business value before adopting a new external tool. This does not mean that the tool itself is less attractive, but rather that the provider needs to show how it fits into existing structures and reduces uncertainty for the customer organization. In this way, organizational readiness becomes closely connected to market adaptation, since the tool needs to be presented and implemented in a way that matches the expectations of the receiving organization.

In this part of the analysis, organizational readiness appears as more than a single factor. It is created through the combination of leadership, employee involvement, technical fit, trust in security and implementation resources. The findings therefore suggest that digital operational tools cannot simply be introduced as isolated technical systems. They need to be embedded into existing routines, supported by managers, trusted by the organization and introduced at a pace that employees can manage. For Swedish digital operational tools in the British market, this means

that adoption depends not only on the quality of the tool, but also on how well the implementation process is supported inside the customer organization.

5.4 Theme 3: Cultural Friction and Cross-Border Market Adaptation

The empirical findings showed that the adoption of digital operational tools was influenced not only by organizational conditions, but also by broader national and cultural differences between operational environments. The interviews highlighted variations connected to decision-making structures, administrative systems, communication patterns, trust building, and levels of digital maturity. These findings can be understood through Ghemawat's (2001) CAGE Distance Framework together with the organizational and cultural perspectives discussed earlier in the literature review.

One major finding concerned differences in decision-making structures and organizational hierarchies. Several respondents described that implementation processes often depended on how decisions were made within the organization and how operational changes were communicated to employees. This reflects the discussion by Yaprak et al., who argue that the organization's employee expectations are very much shaped by the societal and national culture of the country itself. These approaches will also influence communication styles and behaviors in the workplace. In flatter organizational environments, employees may be more involved in operational decision-making and implementation processes. On the other hand, more hierarchical structures may rely more heavily on top-down management and executive approval during digital transformation processes.

Administrative structures and operational compliance routines were also discussed in the findings. These are influenced by how digital systems were integrated into organizations. The description of how reporting systems, centralized operational structures, and existing operational routines influence the organizational work was given by the respondents. If these were not worked on correctly, it could have a negative influence and create additional complexity during the implementation processes. This aligns with Ghemawat's (2001) concept of administrative distance. It explains how differences in institutional structures, regulations, and operational environments may influence international business activities and organizational practices. The findings suggest that digital operational tools cannot be implemented in isolated environments. They must adapt to already existing

reporting systems, organizational routines, and operational structures inside firms. The integration with the ERP system directly is a very important point to keep an eye out for.

Another important finding was the role of trust, communication, and employee involvement during implementation processes. Several respondents explained that employees became more accepting of digital operational systems when they understood the purpose behind the implementation and felt involved in the operational process. This supports the arguments presented by Oyetade et al. (2024), who emphasize that organizational environments encouraging communication, learning, and collaboration are often more supportive toward technological change and digital adoption. The findings further suggest that implementation success depended not only on the technical functionality of the system itself, but also on whether employees trusted the system and understood how it supported their operational work.

The interviews additionally highlighted differences in digital maturity between organizations and employees. It appeared that integrated reporting systems were highly familiar in some organizations whereas in others they were a little bit less familiar. Visual dashboards and real-time operational follow-ups were also very familiar within organizations. Still, many organizations were at the manual reporting and traditional operational methods level of doing things. These findings are closely connected to what was revealed in the literature discussing organizational readiness and digital maturity (Oliveira et al., 2019; Borg et al., 2018). Organizations with stronger digital readiness appeared more comfortable integrating digital operational systems into their existing workflows. At the same time, organizations with less readiness and lower levels of digital familiarity could be in a position to create uncertainty and resistance during the implementation processes.

As a summary to everything, the findings indicate that cross-border adoption of digital operational tools is shaped by a combination of organizational culture, national working environments, communication patterns, and operational structures. The analysis presents the idea of successful implementation, where it may depend on how well digital operational tools are adapted to local organizational practices. The decision making structures and levels of digital maturity within different national and operational contexts are not things to be taken lightly. They are an important part of the whole implementation planning and operation.

5.5 Synthesis of Adoption Factors

Looking across the three themes, adoption appears to depend on how well the tool fits the users, the organization and the market context. TAM helps explain the user side, especially perceived usefulness and ease of use (Marikyan and Papagiannidis, 2025). TOE helps explain organizational conditions such as leadership, training, system fit and security (Oliveira et al., 2019). CAGE adds the cross-country perspective by showing why Swedish and British contexts may shape adoption in different ways (Ghemawat, 2001).
One important point is that the same digital function can be understood differently depending on where it is used. In Sweden, real-time visibility was mainly connected to coordination, overview and improvement in daily operations. In the British context, similar functions were more connected to control, reporting and managerial follow-up. This means that a tool may be useful in both markets, but not always for the same reasons.

This also affects how employees respond to the tool. If they see it as support in their daily work, adoption becomes easier. If they connect it to monitoring, resistance may increase.

At the organizational level, adoption needs practical support. Leadership, training, internal support, system integration and trust in data security all matter. Even a useful tool can become difficult to adopt if employees do not have enough time to learn it, if it does not fit existing routines, or if there is uncertainty around how information will be used.

For Swedish providers, this means that the British market may require clearer business arguments, stronger reassurance around data and security, and more structured implementation support than they are used to. Adoption is not only about presenting the technical functions of the tool. It is also about explaining its value in a way that fits the customer’s routines, expectations and concerns.

6. Conclusion

6.1 Answering the research questions

The main research question of this study examined how organizational and cultural differences may influence the adoption of Swedish digital operational tools within British organizations. The findings suggest that adoption is influenced by considerably more than the technical functionality of the system itself. Organizational culture, communication structures, managerial approaches, operational routines, and national working environments all appeared to shape how digital operational tools were understood, implemented, and integrated into everyday operational activities.

The implementation processes that were presented in the study were often influenced by how organizations approached communication, employee involvement, operational transparency, and decision-making. The collaborative environments, clearer communication structures, and stronger digital readiness within organizations more than often appeared more open towards digital operational systems. While some differences came to light regarding hierarchy, operational structures, and employee familiarity with digital systems, the implementation processes appeared to be influenced by how it was managed across different organizational and national environments.

The findings also suggest that digital operational tools differ from many traditional IT systems because they are closely connected to everyday operational work, communication routines, reporting structures, and performance follow-ups. As a result, implementation processes may become more sensitive to organizational culture and operational behavior inside firms. The study therefore indicates that successful implementation may depend not only on the quality of the digital system itself but also on how well the system fits the operational environment, organizational culture, and working practices of the organizations adopting it.

The first sub-question focused on which organizational and cultural factors influence the adoption of digital operational tools. The findings showed these points: leadership support, employee involvement, communication, training, the organizational readiness, and existing operational routines. All of these played important roles during implementation processes. Organizations where employees understood the purpose of the system and received support throughout implementation generally appeared more open toward adoption. It is worth noting

that culture within organizations had a relevant amount of influence on how employees reacted to technological change, particularly regarding collaboration, learning, flexibility, and openness toward new operational routines.

The second sub-question examined how differences between the Swedish and British business contexts may influence adoption processes. The findings indicated that organizational structures, managerial approaches, and operational environments differed between the two national contexts. Swedish organizations were often associated with flatter organizational structures, collaborative communication, and stronger familiarity with digital operational systems, while several respondents described British operational environments as more hierarchical and compliance-oriented. These differences appeared to influence decision-making processes, implementation structures, and employee responses toward digital operational systems.

The third sub-question explored which barriers and facilitators may arise during implementation processes. The setbacks were connected to barriers, and how they were often connected to resistance toward change, uncertainty, limited training, lower levels of digital maturity, and concerns related to operational disruption. These were shown in the findings. On the other hand, facilitators included leadership support, employee participation, hands-on training, operational transparency, and systems that aligned with already existing work routines. Generally, the higher the level of digital readiness within organizations, the more comfortable the integration of digital operational tools into their operational environments seemed possible.

Taken together, the study suggests that adoption of digital operational tools within B2B operational environments is shaped by a combination of organizational conditions and broader national working environments. Successful implementation, therefore, appears to depend not only on the digital system itself, but also on how well the system fits the operational structures, communication patterns, and organizational culture of the organizations adopting it.

6.2 Theoretical Implications

The theoretical contribution of this study is that it brings together technology acceptance, organizational readiness and cross-country differences. By using TAM, TOE and CAGE together, the study shows that adoption can be understood from several levels at the same time. TAM helps explain usefulness and ease of

use (Marikyan and Papagiannidis, 2025), TOE helps explain organizational and technological conditions (Oliveira et al., 2019), and CAGE helps explain how differences between Sweden and Britain may affect adoption (Ghemawat, 2001).

The findings show that the same digital function can be understood differently depending on the context. Real-time visibility can support coordination and improvement, but it can also be connected to control and monitoring. This means that user acceptance is not only shaped by the tool itself. It is also influenced by leadership, work routines, trust and local expectations.

The study also shows that barriers and facilitators are closely connected. Lack of training, weak system fit and uncertainty around data security can make adoption harder, while leadership support, internal support and gradual implementation can make it easier. This suggests that digital adoption in an international setting should be understood as a process, rather than as a simple decision to accept or reject a tool.

6.3 Practical Implications

The practical implications are mainly relevant for Swedish providers of digital operational tools that are considering the British market. The findings suggest that these firms should not assume that a tool that works well in Sweden will automatically be understood in the same way in Britain. The functions may be the same, but the value may need to be explained differently.

For Swedish SaaS providers such as Boards on Fire (a Swedish SaaS company that develops the digital tools we have been discussing in our research), a potential entry into Britain would require more than presenting the technical features of the platform. British organizations may need a clearer explanation of how the tool supports daily work, improves visibility and helps both managers and employees. At the same time, providers need to be aware that real-time visibility can create hesitation if employees feel that the system is mainly used to watch or control them.

Implementation support also becomes important. British firms may need clear training, internal project leaders, time to learn the system and reassurance around data security. Local understanding can also help build trust, especially when the provider is foreign, and the customer needs to feel that the tool fits its routines, compliance expectations and ways of working.

For Boards on Fire and similar companies, the sales and implementation message may therefore need to be adapted to the British context. In Sweden, it may be natural to emphasize collaboration, transparency and daily improvement. In Britain, it may also be important to show clear business value, explain how the

tool supports reporting and control, and address concerns about security and employee acceptance early in the process.

6.4 Limitations

A few limitations should be noted regarding the scope of this study. The research uses a purely qualitative approach and a multiple case study design. This allows for a detailed understanding of cross border software adoption and implementation challenges, but the findings come from a specific set of firms and cannot be statistically generalized to all SMEs or to other industrial sectors.

The data is also limited to Swedish providers of digital operational tools and their implementation processes in the British market. Because of that, the cultural and administrative dynamics identified through the CAGE framework may not apply in the same way to SaaS adoption in other European or global regions where the institutional environment is different.
Time and resource constraints, which are normal for a Bachelor's level project, limited the sample size and made a longitudinal study unfeasible. The data reflects a specific moment in time. This study captures the organizational readiness and initial technology acceptance during the early stages of cross-border deployment. Rather than tracking how the digital tools were used as well as adopted over several years.

6.5 Suggestion for Future Research

Based on the findings and limitations of this study, there are several directions worth exploring. Future work could use quantitative or mixed methods to build on the qualitative findings presented here. A larger survey would make it possible to test the connections between CAGE, TOE, and TAM statistically, and to see whether the patterns found in this study hold across the wider British SME sector.

A longitudinal study is also highly recommended, given that this research was cross-sectional and captured only the early stages of cross-border deployment. Tracking British firms over a period of two to three years would provide deeper insights into whether user resistance and monitoring anxiety fade as the digital tool becomes institutionalized into daily routines, and whether the role of internal superusers remains critical in the long term.

Expanding the geographic scope beyond Sweden and Britain would be useful too. Applying the same framework to SaaS adoption in markets with different cultural

and administrative settings, such as Southern Europe, North America, or emerging economies, would help to clarify how country level distance shapes individual technology acceptance.

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8. Appendices

8.1 Appendix 1 - Interview guide

Introduction question

- To begin, could you briefly describe your role in the company and how your work connects to operations, planning, communication, or performance follow-up?

Main interview questions:

1. Current practices

1. Could you describe how operations and decision-making are usually organised in your company?
2. What tools do you currently use for planning, communication, and performance follow-up?
3. How is operational information usually shared and followed up in the company?
4. How easy or difficult is it today to get a clear overview of what is happening in daily operations?
5. What parts of your current way of working function well, and what parts are more challenging?

2. Adoption drivers

1. When your company considers a new digital system, what usually matters most in that decision?
2. What would make a digital operational tool useful in your daily work?
3. How important is it that a new digital tool is easy to use?
4. What do you think would make managers and employees more willing to start using a digital operational tool?
5. What benefits would you expect from replacing traditional tools, such as spreadsheets, whiteboards, or manual reporting, with a digital solution?

3. Organizational factors

1. Who is usually involved when decisions are made about adopting new digital tools?
2. How ready would you say the company is to adopt new digital systems?
3. What role does leadership usually play when new tools or systems are introduced?

4. What type of training or support would employees need to feel comfortable using a new digital operational tool?
5. How important is internal communication when a new system is being implemented?

4. Barriers and facilitators

1. In your experience, what usually makes people hesitant when a new system is introduced?
2. How easy or difficult is it to integrate a new digital tool into existing routines and ways of working?
3. Would there be any concerns about adopting a tool from an external SaaS provider?
4. What would make the adoption process easier for your company?
5. If you had to name the biggest barrier to adopting a digital operational tool, what would it be?

5. Cross-country differences

1. Do you see any differences between Swedish and UK companies when it comes to using digital tools in operations?
2. Do you see any cultural differences between Swedish and UK workplaces that may affect how new digital systems are received?
3. How would you compare decision-making processes in Swedish and UK companies?
4. Do you think UK companies may need a different type of support, training, or communication than Swedish companies when adopting digital tools?
5. How important do you think it is for a UK company that the software provider understands the local business culture or has a local presence?

8.2 Appendix 2 - Coding Process

Examples of initial codes	How the codes were grouped	Main theme in the analysis	Theoretical connection
Usefulness, real-time visibility, overview, reduced manual work, improved coordination	Codes related to how users understand the value of the tool	User Perceptions and Operational Friction	TAM: perceived usefulness
Ease of use, usability, complexity, generational gap, digital confidence	Codes related to how easy or difficult the tool feels to use	User Perceptions and Operational Friction	TAM: perceived ease of use
Resistance, fear of monitoring, operational disruption, uncertainty about the system	Codes related to hesitation and friction during use	User Perceptions and Operational Friction	Barriers to adoption / TAM
Leadership, management support, employee involvement, communication of purpose	Codes related to how managers support or shape adoption	Organizational Readiness and Leadership Dynamics	TOE: organizational conditions
Training, internal support, superusers, hands-on guidance, time to learn	Codes related to practical support during implementation	Organizational Readiness and Leadership Dynamics	TOE: organizational readiness and support

System integration, existing IT systems, compatibility, reporting routines	Codes related to whether the tool fits existing systems and work routines	Organizational Readiness and Leadership Dynamics	TOE: technological and organizational fit
Data security, confidentiality, ISO certification, GDPR, trust in provider	Codes related to risk, trust and external provider concerns	Organizational Readiness and Leadership Dynamics	TOE: organizational/environmental conditions
Decision-making style, hierarchy, flat structures, executive mandate, employee involvement	Codes related to how decisions are made in Sweden and Britain	Cultural Friction and Cross-Border Market Adaptation	CAGE: cultural and administrative distance
Local presence, trust-building, market understanding, communication with provider	Codes related to trust and adaptation to the local market	Cultural Friction and Cross-Border Market Adaptation	CAGE: cultural and market adaptation
Digital maturity, Swedish-British differences, skills gap, readiness for digital work	Codes related to different levels of digital readiness across markets	Cultural Friction and Cross-Border Market Adaptation	CAGE and TOE: country context and readiness